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IN BRIEF



Akali chief meets PM, fuels talk of a possible alliance

NEW DELHI/CHANDIGARH With Akali Dal chief Sukhbir Singh Badal meeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday, speculation about the possibility of an alliance with the BJP has once again taken centre stage ahead of the Assembly election. » Page 9

CAG report on AAP's subsidies tabled in House

NEW DELHI The Delhi government tabled a CAG report in the Assembly on Friday, the first day of the four-day Monsoon Session, flagging discrepancies in the previous AAP regime's power subsidy scheme. » Page 2

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, Turkiye ink defence deal

The countries sign the pact pledging a joint response to aggression against any member; it aims at strengthening security and promoting 'peace and stability in the region', says a joint statement

Stanly Johny

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and Turkiye on Friday signed a joint defence agreement in Mecca committing "collective defence" and "collective deterrence", at a time when Saudi Arabia is under attack from Yemen's Houthis and West Asia remains engulfed in the ongoing war against Iran.

The three countries, an oil-rich Persian Gulf kingdom, a South Asian nuclear power and a NATO member, said the pact was aimed at strengthening "collective deterrence" and declared that an armed attack against any one of them would be treated as an attack against them all.

The agreement was signed at the Mecca Al-Mu-



Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, and Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif pose after signing a trilateral defence agreement in Mecca, on Friday. AP

karramah Summit for Joint Defence, attended by Saudi Crown Prince and Prime Minister Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif.

According to a joint an-

of regional issues before signing what was described as the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement.

It added that the pact reflected their commitment to strengthening collective security while promoting "peace, security, and stability in the region and beyond, in pursuit of a secure and prosperous future."

A Turkish government source said the agreement is "a defence-oriented partnership" that does not target any country. "It seeks to strengthen commitments to preserving regional and global peace, stability and prosperity through burden-sharing and collective security," the official added.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10

Is data protection law crippling RTI, asks SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday agreed to examine if the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, can be used to cripple the Right to Information Act by classifying all data as "personal" and, separately, gag investigative journalists.

"The earlier law (RTI Act, 2005) gave certain access with conditions. Here (2023 Act), there is an *en bloc* embargo. Is this latter law repugnant to the earlier law? This has to be looked into with extreme circumspection. After all, both are Central laws. There is a need to harmonise these two," Justice Jy- malya Bagchi remarked.

He said the RTI law operated on a "much larger domain" than the DPDP Act. It covered all forms of data, while the DPDP law was only concerned with data in a digital form. The court said this even though

The earlier law (RTI Act, 2005) gave certain access with conditions. Here (2023 Act), there is an *en bloc* embargo. Is this latter law repugnant to the earlier law? This has to be looked into with extreme circumspection



acknowledging that the data was now overwhelmingly in the digital format.

The judge said the court would examine if this restrictive or "cautious approach" to sharing data under the DPDP Act worked to repeal earlier transparency laws.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10

Why can't two States hold talks: Vijay on Cauvery issue

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Speaking in the Assembly on the Cauvery water-sharing issue and the proposed Mokedatu dam, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday said, "When even enemy countries hold talks to resolve disputes, there is nothing wrong with neighbouring States holding discussions." The Chief Minister said the Cauvery is the State's lifeline and an emotional issue, and asserted that his government did not have "even an iota of intention" to politicise it.

He added that his government would never compromise on Tamil Nadu's rights regarding the sharing of Cauvery water or the construction of the Mokedatu dam. "That is our stand," he said.

DETAILS ON » PAGE 4

Troubled waters



Adrift: Commuters wading through a waterlogged road in near Rajghat on Friday. PTI (REPORT ON PAGE 2)

Oppn. cannot dictate who responds in House: Rijiju

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Friday rejected the Opposition's demand that Home Minister Amit Shah respond in Parliament to allegations of police excesses against students protesting against the NEET paper leak, asserting that the Opposition could not dictate which Minister should answer in the House.

DETAILS ON » PAGE 11

NTA experts leaked NEET questions via notes, messaging apps, says CBI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which recently filed a chargesheet against 13 accused persons in the NEET-UG 2026 examination paper leak case, has alleged that the subject experts engaged by the National Testing Agency (NTA) leaked questions through handwritten notes, following which they were circulated via digital messaging platforms.

The accused experts included Manisha Sanjay Havaladar for physics, Manisha Gurunath Mandhare for biology, and P.V. Kulkarni for chemistry.

Ms. Havaladar translated one set and "back-translated/proofread" three sets of questions. According to the CBI, she allegedly remembered the questions



Those arrested in the NEET-UG paper leak case are being investigated by the CBI. ANI

and noted them down after returning from the NTA's "confidential section" premises. The questions were allegedly passed first to accused Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, a physics faculty at a Pune coaching centre, the Dr. Abhang Prabhu Medical Academy (APMA).

The biology questions were allegedly sent from Ms. Mandhare to Pune-based beauty salon owner and alleged intermediary

Manisha Sanjay Waghmare, who also collected chemistry questions. Ms. Waghmare forwarded them to Dhananjay Lokhande, who in turn passed them to Shubham Khairnar for onward distribution. The questions allegedly reached Yash Yadav in Haryana's Gurugram before being distributed further to Mangilal Biwal, Dinesh Biwal, and Vikas Biwal from Jaipur, Rajasthan,

among others.

Mr. Kulkarni allegedly used the plain sheets made available for rough work to note down on small chits the chemistry questions in brief as well as their answers, and took them out of the NTA premises in a concealed manner. The agency found that experts were not frisked and their possessions were not checked during entry or exit. The accused did back-translation work for three sets of questions.

The chemistry questions were allegedly circulated through two parallel channels, one involving Ms. Waghmare and another through a Latur-based doctor named Manoj Shirure. The doctor shared them with Shivraj Mote-gaonkar, the owner of the RCC Coaching Institute in Maharashtra's Latur, the CBI has alleged.

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A ND-NDE

PM to address 57th IIT Delhi convocation, launch facility

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will address the 57th convocation of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi on Saturday, where more than 3,000 graduating students, including 587 PhD scholars, will be conferred their degrees.

IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee said the Prime Minister will remotely inaugurate an AI-powered high-performance supercomputing facility established at the institute's Sonipat campus.

In a release, the Prime Minister's Office stated, "The state-of-the-art facility is expected to significantly enhance the institute's capabilities in AI, data science, advanced computing, and interdisciplinary research."

The institute stated that the Sonipat campus had achieved a significant milestone this year with the completion of a 9,500-square metre advanced research and academic building. The facility includes laboratories for the Centre for Optics and Photonics and instrumentation for the Central Research Facility.

₹42 crore of lapses in 3 years': CAG report on AAP's power subsidies tabled in Assembly

Audit, tabled on the first day of Monsoon Session, also flags ₹220.59 cr. in tax, fee discrepancies in 145 cases; Opposition party criticises BJP govt. for not including Question Hour in four-day session

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Monsoon Session of the Delhi Assembly began on Friday with the Opposition questioning the absence of Question Hour, even as the Bharatiya Janata Party government tabled a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report flagging discrepancies in the previous Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) regime's power subsidy scheme.

AAP MLA Sanjeev Jha criticised the government for not allowing Question Hour, saying legislators had been submitting questions without getting an opportunity to raise them in the House. "What are we submitting questions for?" said the Burari MLA.

Aid for 'non-consumers' The audit, covering 2019-20 to 2022-23, flagged several discrepancies, including ₹42.26 crore in subsidies extended to domestic consumers with no recorded consumption over consecutive billing cycles.

The report also questioned the framework of the scheme, observing that consumers with higher electricity consumption received substantially higher subsidies per connection. More than 30 lakh consumers using up to 200 units a month received an average annual subsidy of about ₹6,000 per connection. In contrast, around 16.60 lakh consumers consuming more than 200 units received an average subsidy of over ₹10,000 – nearly 70% higher.



CM Rekha Gupta being greeted by women on the opening day of the 4-day Monsoon Session, in New Delhi on Friday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

secutive billing cycles.

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in south-west Delhi's Baprola in 2006 for a Gems and Jewellery Park and Fashion Design Hub.

The House also passed a Motion of Thanks on the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, the government's scheme to provide ₹2,500 in financial assistance to women.

Till Friday, over 4.87 lakh women had registered on the official portal.

Nod to pvt. universities Meanwhile, the Chief Minister's Office issued a release stating that the Cabinet has approved a draft Bill to establish private universities in the national capital, which will be introduced in the Monsoon Session for approval.

Currently, no legal framework exists in Delhi for establishing private universities. According to the statement, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta pointed out that the absence of a legal framework "had led many students to move to neighbouring States or abroad in search of quality higher education".

Roads flooded; students reach their school on makeshift raft

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Heavy rain lashed Delhi on Friday, inundating low-lying areas, disrupting traffic and affecting normal life across the Capital.

The impact was particularly severe in south Delhi's Fatehpur Beri, where residents of Valmiki Basti used a large blue plastic sheet as a makeshift raft to ferry children to school through waist-deep water.

The colony has faced flooding for nearly six decades, residents said, blaming an incomplete stormwater drain and alleged encroachments downstream for the recurring problem.

"There is a government drain here, but further ahead farmhouse owners have blocked it," said Rishipal Mashe, a resident.

"Nearly five feet of water has filled the entire village. Water has entered our houses, damaging whatever food and household belongings we had," said another resident.



Residents carrying children on a mat in Chhatarpur; (below) people wading through waterlogged GTK Road. ANI, SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Wall collapse kills two In Gurugram, two labourers died after a wall of a private school collapsed following heavy rain in DLF Phase-2, the police said. The men, identified as Suraj and Dayanand, both natives of Meerut district in Uttar Pradesh, had been engaged to remove old trees and plant new ones. They took shelter at the building during heavy rain when the dilapidated wall gave way.

Their bodies were sent for post-mortem examination and a probe is under way, the police said.

The Delhi Fire Services received more than two dozen calls involving house collapses, building portions giving way and fallen trees between midnight and 5.30 p.m.

In one of the incidents, three women were trapped in a house after a

Traffic impacted Waterlogging disrupted traffic in parts of the city. Heavy congestion was reported on Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, ITO, Wazirabad Road, Patel Road, Rohtak Road, Shankar Road, Kirti Nagar, the Delhi-Jaipur Highway, Peeragarhi, Shaheen Bagh and the Delhi cantonment underpass. Traffic also slowed down on GT Road, GTB Enclave and Dilshad Garden.

Vehicles in Manglupuri had to sail through two-foot-deep water while many were stranded on the Dwarka flyover.

Waterlogging was also reported in Mahipalpur, Chhatarpur, Shakarpur, Dakshinpuri, Okhla, Sangam Vihar, Sainik Farms and areas around the Red Fort. In Shakarpur and Mandawali, e-rickshaw drivers reported accidents caused by submerged

potholes and sewer pits.

"At least three or four vehicles have overturned today, including e-rickshaws, scooters and motorcycles," said an e-rickshaw driver.

Meanwhile, Public Works Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said key waterlogging hotspots did not witness inundation and that waterlogging was mainly reported in some villages and rural areas where drainage work was under way.

Aam Aadmi Party Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj criticised the government over waterlogging in parts of the city.

The Safdarjung weather station recorded 116.5 mm of rainfall till 5.30 p.m. on Friday, according to the India Meteorological Department. It has forecast moderate to heavy rains in the Capital over the weekend, and light to very light rainfall till August 13.

(With inputs from PTI)

Metro security checks to intensify from tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of Independence Day, security has been stepped up at metro stations across the Capital, with checks to be intensified from Sunday, officials said on Friday.

In a statement, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said the Central Industrial Security Force

(CISF) would carry out intensified checking across stations as part of the security arrangements for August 15.

Passengers may face longer queues at some stations, especially during peak hours, till August 16, the DMRC said. It advised commuters to plan their journeys accordingly and allow additional time for security checks.

The DMRC also appealed to passengers to cooperate with security personnel during the checking process. Officials said no metro gates would be closed on Independence Day unless directed by security agencies.

On August 15, metro services will commence at 4 a.m. to facilitate the movement of people attending the Independence Day ceremony at Red Fort.

Mock drill conducted As part of heightened security preparedness in the city, a multi-agency mock anti-terror drill simulating bomb explosions was conducted at Nehru Place on Friday, the police said.

Held between 10 a.m. and 11.20 a.m., the exercise assessed response time, communication and

coordination.

A simulated PCR call triggered the response, with evacuation drills carried out and the area cordoned off. Bomb disposal teams conducted checks, traffic was regulated, and a mock-injured person was shifted to AIIMS within 20 minutes. The drill involved several agencies, including the National Security Guard and Delhi Police.

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Dated this 20th day of June 2026
Advocates KA Nidhin & KR Arunasree

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DU students struggle with soaring rents, fraud as new academic session begins

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

As thousands of students arrive in the Capital for the new academic session at Delhi University, the excitement of beginning university life is giving way to an exhausting search for accommodation in a rental market marked by soaring rents, exploitative brokerage practices, withheld security deposits, and a chronic shortage of affordable housing.

Students across neighbourhoods surrounding the university told *The Hindu* that securing even modest accommodation has become difficult, straining family finances and leaving many vulnerable in an unfamiliar environment.

High rentals For 18-year-old Ahmed, who moved from Kargil in Ladakh, the accommodation search began with a shock, with PGs near his college asking ₹20,000 to ₹22,000 a month for single



Finding an accommodation near Delhi University has become a challenge for many freshers. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

rooms without basic facilities.

To avoid this, he stayed with friends in Vijay Nagar before renting a one-room set for ₹10,500, saying, "It is just one room with a washroom and a shelf as a kitchen, with no ventilation or proper facilities. It is simply not worth it."

Manisha, who arrived from West Bengal on July 28, said she spent over a week finding a shared room in Ghanta Ghar, about 2 km from her college, where she pays ₹6,000 a month excluding food and transport. "I receive only ₹10,000 from home every month, so I usually walk to save money," she said.

The challenges are more severe for students with disabilities.

Himanshi, who moved from Bihar, said she has been unable to find a suitable home. "Many properties lack ramps, and lifts are too small for my wheelchair. Even a basic one-bed-

room set is being quoted at nearly ₹40,000 in some places," she said.

Rental fraud Instances of rental fraud have also emerged. Santosh, a postgraduate student, said he paid a token amount and advance rent after seeing photographs of a property online, only to find it entirely different on arrival.

A property broker in Rohini, speaking on condition of anonymity, said the start of every academic session brings a surge in demand, particularly from students arriving from Bihar, Punjab, the Northeast and southern States.

He said students from outside Delhi are often charged more than residents. "A bed in a PG may cost around ₹7,000 for locals but ₹11,000 for outsiders, and even poorly maintained flats near campuses are rented for ₹17,000 to ₹20,000," he said.

(Names of some students changed on request)

63-year-old digital arrest victim seeks CBI probe

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

A 63-year-old woman has moved the Delhi High Court seeking the transfer of the investigation into her digital arrest complaint to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

The court has issued notices to the CBI, Delhi Police, the Delhi government, and the Union Ministry of Home Affairs, and directed the Delhi police to file a status report.

The petitioner alleged that she was subjected to sustained harassment and

coercion by fraudsters posing as officials of the Mumbai Crime Branch between November 1 and 19, 2025.

According to the writ petition, the accused informed her that her Aadhaar number had been linked to terrorist funding and that she faced immi-

nent arrest. Under duress, she transferred ₹1.06 crore to multiple bank accounts provided by the accused.

A senior police officer said the investigation is ongoing and that a city-based accused linked to the first layer of transactions had been arrested.

Assam flood toll rises to 98

Press Trust of India
GUWAHATI

The flood situation in As-
sam remained grim on Fri-
day, with the death toll ris-
ing to 98, even as the
number of affected dis-
tricts declined to 13 and the
number of people impact-
ed by the deluge came
down to 1.55 lakh, accord-
ing to an official bulletin.
The Assam State Disas-
ter Management Authority
(ASDMA) bulletin said the
latest death was reported
from the Mahmora reve-
nue circle in Charaideo
district.
Thirteen districts – Siva-
sagar, Golaghat, Nagaon,
Hojai, Sonitpur, Dhemaji,
Darrang, Biswanath, Kam-
rup (M), Lakhimpur, Udal-
guri, Jorhat and Charaideo
– continued to remain af-
fected by floodwaters, im-
pacting 33 revenue circles
and 464 villages.

Timings

DELHI

SATURDAY, AUG. 08

RISE 05:47

SET 19:07

RISE 00:33

SET 15:19

SUNDAY, AUG. 09

RISE 05:47

SET 19:06

RISE 01:33

SET 16:24

MONDAY, AUG. 10

RISE 05:48

SET 19:05

RISE 02:40

SET 17:23

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	28	26
Safdarjang	28	26
Palam	27	23

Delhi Palam Today
29°C The weather will be sight
warm. Few spells of light to
moderate rain and thunder-
shower to occur. Night will be
comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
32°C The weather will be little
warm. Spell of light rain and
thundershower to occur. Night
will be comfortable.

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Punjab govt. employees stage protest over pending demands

Police use water cannons to disperse protesters marching towards State Assembly; protesters say govt. failed to meet demands despite repeated assurances, warn of Statewide stir on August 27

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Scores of Punjab go-
vernment em-
ployees and pen-
sioners on Friday took out
a massive protest rally in
Chandigarh over various
demands, including the re-
lease of pending dearness
allowance (DA) and regu-
larisation of contractual
employees.
The Chandigarh police
stopped the employees
from marching towards the
Punjab Assembly, where
the Monsoon Session was
under way, and used water
cannons to disperse the
protesters who had assem-
bled in large numbers.
The protest was held
under the banner of Sanj-
ha Mulazam and Pension-
ers' Front and Sanjha Mu-
lazam Manch, Punjab, with
several employees' organi-
sations taking part from va-
rious parts of the State.
The employees have been
demanding release of



Protesters getting sprayed by water cannons in Chandigarh on Friday. Several outfits took part in the rally. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

pending 18% DA, imple-
mentation of old pension
scheme and regularisation
of contractual employees.
The employees said des-
pite repeated assurance,
the State government
failed to address their
demands.

An employees' organisa-
tion leader Sukhchain
Singh Khaira said govern-
ment employees, includ-
ing teachers, technical
staff, Class IV employees,
ministerial staff, engineers,
medical staff and several
others, joined the demon-

stration to express their an-
guish against the Aam Aad-
mi Party (AAP)
government. "The State
government has only been
giving assurances. We will
observe a complete strike
on August 27 if our de-
mands are not met by
then," he said.

Opposition parties also
criticised the AAP govern-
ment. Senior Congress
leader and Leader of the
Opposition in the State As-
sembly Partap Singh Bajwa
extended his support to
the protesting employees,

describing their agitation
as "their legitimate fight
for their rightful dues".
"Their demand for the re-
lease of pending DA is both
just and long overdue. I
reiterate that the Congress
party and I stand firmly
with them and will support
their movement. The voic-
es of Punjab's employees
cannot be ignored any lon-
ger," he said.

Punjab Congress chief
Amrinder Singh Raja War-
ring said it was these em-
ployees who voted for the
AAP in the State. "Today,
in 2026, the same em-
ployees are taking to the
streets and saying, 'We
don't want this govern-
ment'. What could be a big-
ger report card for the AAP
government than this?"
Mr. Warring asked.

Shiromani Akali Dal pre-
sident Sukhbir Badal said
the AAP government was
treating its employees like
enemies and that the party
had lost all moral right to
govern.

Ahead of 2027 poll, U.P. RLD chief quits, flags 'divisive politics'

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Rashtriya Lok Dal's (RLD)
Uttar Pradesh president Ra-
mashish Rai resigned on
Friday citing "attacks on in-
stitutions and rampant cor-
ruption" in the country.

The RLD is the largest
constituent of the Bharatiya
Janata Party-led National
Democratic Alliance (NDA)
government in the poll-
bound State and a partner
in the ruling NDA at the
Centre.

"Our leader [RLD found-
er] Ajit Singhji used to take
a clear stand on the issues
of farmers and youth, even
if that meant going against
the wind. However, we re-
mained silent when stu-
dents and youth came out
to protest. This has never
been the RLD style of polit-
ics," Mr. Rai told *The Hindu*.

In a letter to the party's
president and Union Minis-
ter of State for Skill Devel-
opment and Education,
Jayant Chaudhary, Mr. Rai
stated that democracy is be-
ing "usurped" by the po-
werful and society is being

divided along caste and re-
ligion lines for poll gains. He
alleged that matters of pu-
blic interest such as educa-
tion and employment are
being neglected.

Talking about his deci-
sion to quit the party, Mr.
Rai said, "I was pained. I en-
tered social service during
the anti-Emergency move-
ment. My inner voice forced
me to part ways with the
RLD in the wider interests
of society and Indian de-
mocracy."

When asked whether he
had plans to join any other
political party, he said he
would take any decision af-
ter consulting supporters
and well-wishers. "The
main concern right now is
to save the democratic and
socialist fabric of our coun-
try," Mr. Rai said.

In a late evening devel-
opment, the RLD appointed
Aishwarya Raj Singh as its
new State president. He has
earlier served the party in
various roles.

The RLD won two seats
in the 2024 Lok Sabha elec-
tion and has one member in
the Rajya Sabha.

ISKCON event cancelled after protests by JNUSU

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Jawaharlal Nehru Uni-
versity Students' Union
(JNUSU) on Friday held a
protest outside the Central
library against an event that
was to feature an ISKCON
representative, following
which the programme was
cancelled, according to the
student body members.

The programme, titled
'Empowering Youth for a
Brighter Future', also in-
cluded a session on "Bal-
ancing EQ, IQ and SQ", ac-
cording to posters and
information shared by the
union office-bearers.

JNUSU general secretary
Sunil Yadav said objections
were raised last year as well
with the university admin-
istration over the permis-
sion granted to ISKCON to
hold an event on the Bhaga-
vad Gita on the campus.
"On Friday, a representa-
tive from the same organi-
sation was supposed to
speak at the library," Mr. Ya-
dav said. "Following the
protest, they had to cancel
the event."

SC asks two Ghaziabad hospitals to pay ₹12 lakh to father of rape victim

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Fri-
day directed two private
hospitals in Ghaziabad to
pay a total of ₹12 lakh to the
family of a four-year-old
rape victim who died after
allegedly being denied
emergency medical

treatment.
Observing that the case
exposed a "disturbing" gap
between legal safeguards
and their implementation
on the ground, a Bench said
it would frame broad guide-
lines for hospitals and law
enforcement agencies on
handling victims of grave
offences to ensure that such

lapses do not recur. The
court took note of the SIT's
findings that the child re-
mained alive for nearly five
hours after sustaining grie-
vous injuries but was de-
nied timely medical care.
The Bench was hearing a
petition filed by the girl's
father, a daily wage
labourer.

Gurugram civic body chief reappointed within 24 hrs.

Press Trust of India
GURUGRAM

Just 24 hours after transfer-
ring him, the Haryana go-
vernment on Friday reap-
pointed IAS officer Pradeep
Dahiya as the Commission-
er of the Gurugram Muni-
cipal Corporation.
According to an official

order, the government had
transferred him on Thurs-
day as Rohtak DC.

Alongside this, the State
government also carried
out a major administrative
reshuffle. Orders were is-
sued for the transfer and
new posting of 17 IAS and 7
Haryana Civil Service offi-
cers, it said.

APPOINTMENT

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INBRIEF



Shah likely to hold meeting with TMP chief over alliance

Union Home Minister Amit Shah is likely to hold a meeting with Tipra Motha Party (TMP) founder Pradyot Kishore Debbarma and Tripura Chief Minister Manik Saha in New Delhi on Saturday to stitch an alliance for the upcoming village committee (VC) polls in the tribal council area of the northeastern State, a party leader said. Elections to 587 VCs will be held in the first half of next month. “Mr. Debbarma and party general secretary Brishaketu Debbarma are scheduled to visit Delhi during the day for the meeting. BJP’s Northeast coordinator Sambit Patra is also expected to remain present,” TMP MLA Ranjit Debbarma said. PTI

3 paraded with barbed wires around their necks in M.P.

Three men were paraded with bundles of barbed wire around their necks as locals kicked, punched and beat them with slippers over suspicion of theft in Madhya Pradesh’s Chhindwara district, police said on Friday. A video of the assault has gone viral on social media. It shows a group of people, including security guards of the State-run Western Coalfields Limited (WCL), targeting the men over cable theft in the Iklehra township, police said. Police inspector Khemchand Patel said action will also be taken against those who assaulted the youths. PTI

Cauvery row: when enemy countries can hold talks, why not States, says Vijay

T.N. CM asserts govt. firm in pursuing legal remedies; says it was worth making an attempt to visit Bengaluru, will never compromise on State’s rights on Cauvery water or Mekedatu construction

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday said it was his idea to visit Bengaluru to hold talks with the Karnataka government on the issue of sharing Cauvery water.

“When even enemy countries hold talks to resolve disputes, there is nothing wrong with neighbouring States holding discussions,” Mr. Vijay said, while replying to a special calling attention motion in the Legislative Assembly on the Cauvery water-sharing issue and the proposed Mekedatu dam.

‘Worth an attempt’

Making it clear that his government remained firm in pursuing legal remedies, the Chief Minister said he had nevertheless felt it was worth making an attempt to visit Bengaluru.

“I thought about it and sought to do it. There were many views and opinions on my proposed visit to



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay during the State Legislative Assembly session in Chennai on Friday. PTI

Bengaluru. I saw it as a positive step towards resolving the problem. Even if I had to face humiliation in that attempt, I was prepared to do so for the sake of the people of Tamil Nadu. I thank everyone who expressed their affection and support,” he said.

Mr. Vijay said the Cauvery was the State’s lifeline and an emotional issue, and asserted that his government did not have “even an iota of intention” to politicise it.

Recalling the unanimous Assembly resolution opposing the Mekedatu project, and its subsequent transmission to the Prime

Minister, he said the government had not stopped with that.

“When we learnt the Union Minister of State for Jal Shakti had not presented the full facts regarding the Mekedatu issue, we wrote to the Prime Minister again, quoting relevant portions of the final order of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal and the Supreme Court judgment. We urged him not to grant administrative or any other approval to Karnataka for the construction of the dam,” he said.

The Chief Minister asserted that his government would never compromise

on Tamil Nadu’s rights in relation to the sharing of Cauvery water or the construction of the Mekedatu dam. “That is our stand,” he said.

Referring to the Assembly debate in 1969 on Karnataka’s decision to construct dams across the Cauvery, Mr. Vijay asked, “Who was the Water Resources Minister then? I do not indulge in cheap politics by asking who permitted Karnataka to construct those dams. That is not our objective, because the Cauvery issue must be handled with utmost care.”

He also recalled the remarks of the then Leader of the Opposition, P.G. Karuthiruman, who had said: “We should not worry about which party gets the credit. This is a problem concerning the people of Tamil Nadu.” Mr. Vijay said the Assembly had then debated the need for the two States and the Centre to hold discussions on the issue. “The situation, however, changed completely later,” he said.

HC closes criminal cases linked to 2015 Maggi controversy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

More than a decade after the controversy over alleged excessive lead content in Maggi, the Delhi High Court has quashed criminal proceedings against Nestlé India officials and distributors, noting that subsequent scientific testing found the product’s lead content to be within the permissible limit.

Justice Madhu Jain, in a judgment pronounced on Thursday, said continuing the prosecutions would amount to an abuse of the process of law as the very scientific foundation of the cases had substantially eroded following fresh tests conducted by the Central Food Technological Research Institute (CFTRI) under the Supreme Court’s supervision.

The court consequently quashed the criminal complaints, the summoning orders issued in 2015 and 2016, and all consequential proceedings against the retailers and other persons in the supply chain of Nestlé.

The cases arose from samples of Maggi noodles collected by Delhi food safety officials during the nationwide sampling drive in

May 2015. Food analysts had reported that the lead content in the tastemaker exceeded the permissible limit of 2.5 parts per million (ppm), while one complaint also alleged misbranding over the “no added MSG” declaration. Based on these findings, complaints were filed under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, leading to criminal prosecution against retailers, suppliers and representatives of Nestlé India.

‘Permissible limits’

The petitioners argued that the prosecutions could not survive because the Bombay High Court had in 2015 set aside the nationwide ban on Maggi noodles after finding that the laboratories whose reports formed the basis of the ban lacked the statutory accreditation under the Food Safety and Standards Act. They also relied on subsequent testing by accredited laboratories and the CFTRI, which reportedly found the lead content to be within permissible limits. Justice Jain said, “This court is of the considered view that permitting the present prosecutions to continue would serve no useful purpose.”

BJP suspends 9 workers over slogans at rally

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

The BJP on Friday suspended nine party workers following an outcry over slogans, allegedly berating Kashmir women, raised during a rally celebrating abrogation of Article 370 in south Kashmir’s Anantnag on August 5.

“It has been unanimously decided to initiate strict disciplinary action against those found responsible for organising and participating in the unauthorised rally,” said the BJP.

The BJP said it took serious note of the objectionable and derogatory remarks.

Meanwhile, suspended BJP workers tendered apology on social media platforms over sloganeering.

Police question Ittija; attempt to silence PDP, says Mehbooba

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The J&K police questioned Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) leader Ittija Mufti on Friday, a day after an FIR was filed against the party and its leaders following street protests in Srinagar on August 4 to mark the seventh anniversary of the abrogation of Article 370 on August 5. J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah described the arrest as “a fixed match”.

Ms. Ittija arrived at the Kothibagh police station in Srinagar around 2 p.m. and was subjected to on-camera questioning for around two hours. The FIR mentioned PDP president Mehbooba Mufti and her daughter Ittija. Ahead of her daughter’s questioning, Ms. Mehbooba



PDP leader Ittija Mufti on her way to the police station in Srinagar on Friday. IMRAN NISSAR

ba addressed party cadre at PDP headquarters in Srinagar. She alleged that the police FIR was an attempt “to silence the party”. “A male constable was directed to drag Ittija. Should a policeman touch a woman? When a woman is held by her neck, what should she do? It’s unfortunate,” she said.

Uproar over ‘He Ram’, ‘Space Rani’ clearing exam in Chhattisgarh

Press Trust of India
RAIPUR

Chhattisgarh’s latest police recruitment exam results have drawn widespread attention after a bizarre mix of candidate names, such as ‘News’, ‘Space Rani’, ‘He Ram’, Bhakt Prahlad, and ‘Tufail’, surfaced on the qualifying list, prompting the Opposition Congress to allege irregularities, even as candidates came forward to defend their unique monikers.

While the Congress seized upon the peculiar roster of names to allege irregularities in the preliminary recruitment exam for the 341 posts of subedar, sub-inspector and platoon commander held on on July 12, the Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission reject-

ed the claim, saying the records accurately reflect the data provided by candidates during registration.

The commission clarified that these candidates had appeared for document verification, physical tests and the preliminary examination under the same names, also printed on their admit cards.

The preliminary result was declared on August 4, with 7,301 candidates qualifying for the mains.

Congress leaders questioned the recruitment process, with former Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel taking a dig at the government over the names. He claimed that the names on the list showed the CGPSC and the government’s alleged “negligence” in conducting examinations.

‘Trouble engine’: Oppn. attacks U.P. govt. after Governor flags lapses in Gorakhpur varsity

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

A day after Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel pointed out various deficiencies in the functioning of Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Gorakhpur University, the Opposition parties on Friday hit out at the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government, saying the “Gorakhpur model” had been exposed.

In her address to students during the university’s 45th convocation ceremony, the Governor said, “Of the six hostels for boys, two are under repair. While there is a mess facility in the girls’ hostels, the boys’ hostels lack this amenity. Instead, the boys receive their meals through a tiffin service. Do



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav said Governor Patel had exposed the ‘Gorakhpur Model’. FILE PHOTO

you believe this is satisfactory?” “These deficiencies need to be resolved within three months. This is Gorakhpur, the city of our Chief Minister [Yogi Adityanath]. How can such conditions persist here?” remarked the Governor.

In a post on X tagging a video of Ms. Patel’s speech,

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav said in Hindi: “While exposing the ‘Gorakhpur model’, the scandal surrounding the ‘Gujarat model’ has also surfaced. The common denominator between the two is the BJP and rampant corruption. Mutual conflict has turned the ‘double engine’ into a ‘trouble engine’.”

‘Misgovernance in State’ Congress national secretary Shahnawaz Alam said the Governor’s views validate the Opposition’s allegations about misgovernance in the State.

“The administration in Uttar Pradesh has collapsed completely, which forced the constitutional functionary to speak openly,” he said.

Bihar model schools get a fresh coat of ‘sunshine’ after paint mandate

Amarnath Tewary
BEGUSARAI

In view of the Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance government’s recent decision to repaint and rename all 551 model schools across Bihar as ‘Saraswati Vidya Niketan’, the schools have begun repainting their exterior walls in the prescribed “sunrise” colour – a shade that closely resembles the saffron colour associated with the BJP.

The exterior walls of B.P. High School in Begusarai, where Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and State Education Minister Mithilesh Tiwari visited on July 19 and announced the new scheme, are now painted in the sunrise colour. The new name – Saraswati Vidya Niketan – has been also printed on polymer signboards in what



The exterior walls of B.P. Inter School in Begusarai repainted according to the government’s directive. AMARNATH TEWARY

some officials described as done in “just three days” with lakhs of rupees spent on the exercise.

However, school principal Kamini Kumari said the school, which had been painted only a few days earlier, had to be repainted following the fresh government directive.

“We have to follow whatever directive or guideline comes from above,” said the principal.

The main gate of the

school, established in 1888, now bears a board identifying it as Saraswati Vidya Niketan, B.P. Inter School, Begusarai. “From July 16 to 18, we engaged nearly 50 workers to give the building a fresh coat of the suggested colour and completed the work ahead of the Chief Minister’s visit,” added Ms. Kamini.

District Education Officer Manoj Kumar said, “Begusarai district has 18 blocks, but we have four

additional model schools because the district is large. Work is under way in every model school as per department’s guidelines.”

State directive

The Bihar State Educational Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd., which looks after the renovation and construction of government schools, issued a letter on July 7 to all its district units regarding the repainting of the schools.

“Earlier, schools in Bihar were painted in pink, sky blue or white, which looked decent and could be identified from afar. But this new ‘sunrise’ colour, which prominently resembles saffron, has acquired an altogether different connotation,” said a retired government school teacher.

After 3 years of court dates and police station visits, father of JU ragging victim still awaits justice

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Three years after his 17-year-old son died, the father of Jadavpur University ragging victim continues to wait for justice, with trial hearings repeatedly postponed and several people named in the university’s internal inquiry yet to face action.

The young student died following “severe ragging” and a fall from the second-floor balcony of the university’s main hostel, located beside the Jadavpur Police Station, on August 9, 2023. He had allegedly faced ragging, harassment and mental torture at the hands of other hostel boarders, including former and then current university students.

The chargesheet in the



Students protesting against ragging at Jadavpur University. FILE PHOTO

case was filed in October 2023, and the trial began in March 2024. However, speaking to *The Hindu*, the victim’s father said that justice has continued to elude him even after continued visits to the court and police station.

He said that no one turns up for the hearings, which are now under way at the Protection of Chil-

dren from Sexual Offences court in Kolkata, and the dates are postponed each time. “I am completely alone, poor and powerless. Why should I have to bear the burden of losing my child when the people who abused him and caused his death are roaming about freely?” the father said.

So far, the Kolkata police have arrested 12 people in connection with the case. However, the victim’s father said that the internal inquiry conducted by the university had identified several other accused persons in connection with the incident.

“What happened to all these people who were named in JU’s own internal investigation? Why have they not been brought to justice?” the victim’s father said.

TCS case: AIMIM corporator arrested

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The police have arrested Mateen Patel, a corporator of the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM), from Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar in connection with the TCS harassment case on Friday. The arrest follows a non-bailable warrant issued against Mr. Patel for failing to appear before the court despite summons.

Mr. Patel has been accused of sheltering Nida Khan, the main accused in the case. The case pertains to allegations of harassment at the Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) office in Nashik. Earlier, the district administration had demolished Mr. Patel’s house and office structures for alleged illegal constructions.

‘Centre mulls separate law for women farmer rights’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Union government is considering a separate legislation to protect the rights of women farmers, on the lines of the Maharashtra Women Farmers Empowerment Act, 2026, S. Mahendra Dev, Chairman of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister, said in Chennai on Friday.

Speaking at the inauguration of a conference on ‘Building Gender-just Food, Land, and Water Systems’ at the M.S. Swaminathan Research Foundation (MSSRF), Professor Dev described the Maharashtra law as a landmark legislation and said other States could draw inspiration from it. “The Centre is also discussing something similar,” he said.

Highlighting the need to place women at the centre of agrifood systems, he said agriculture should shift from being production-centric to income-centric. This, he said, could be achieved through crop diversification, better post-harvest marketing, food and agro-processing, and institutional support to enhance farmers’ incomes.

Aditi Sunil Tatkare, Maharashtra’s Minister for Women and Child Development, said the legislation reflected the government’s commitment to recognising women farmers through policy measures. She said the Bill received support across party lines, when it was introduced in the Assembly.

SC to decide on Tamil Nadu’s quota for converted Muslims

State says its 2024 order was to ensure ‘persons belonging to socially and educationally backward communities are not deprived of reservation benefits solely on account of conversion to Islam’

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday agreed to pronounce judgment on a Tamil Nadu government appeal seeking confirmation of the State’s power to frame and implement policy to provide reservation benefits to members of backward classes, most backward classes, denotified communities and Scheduled Castes who convert to Islam.

A Bench headed by Justice Prashant Kumar Mishra reserved orders on the State government’s stand that it has the authority, based on the Tamil Nadu Backward Classes Commission, to issue “backward



A Supreme Court Bench has reserved orders on the State government’s stance.

classes (Muslim) community certificates to eligible persons who had embraced Islam among the backward classes, most backward classes, denotified communities and Scheduled Castes”.

The State, represented by senior advocates Mukul

Rohatgi and Siddharth Luthra, said the object behind its government order of March 9, 2024 was to ensure that “persons belonging to socially and educationally backward communities are not deprived of reservation benefits solely on account of conversion to Islam and thereby create a level playing field by preserving affirmative action benefits despite change of religion”.

The State appeal was directed against a Madras High Court decision quashing the March 2024 order as unconstitutional.

The High Court judgment of June 25, 2026 had held that “a person who embraces Islam cannot claim the status of back-

ward class (Muslim)”.

Justice Mishra orally observed that a 1951 judgment of the Madras High Court in *G. Michael versus S. Venkateswaran*, regarding a Scheduled Caste member who converted to Christianity and wanted to contest in a reserved seat, had held the fort for 75 years by upholding the constitutional validity of Paragraph 3 of the Constitution (Scheduled Castes) Order, 1950.

Paragraph 3 stipulated that no person who professed a religion different from Hinduism (later amended to include Sikhism and Buddhism) should be deemed to get the benefits of a Scheduled Caste member.

Officials told to camp at rail accident sites to aid probe

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Senior railway officers probing train accidents have been directed to camp at accident sites to expedite investigations and ensure that inquiry reports are completed within the prescribed time frame.

According to railway sources, a safety review of accident investigations conducted by the Railway Board found that several accident inquiries and related departmental proceedings had not been finalised within the stipulated deadlines.

The review pointed to delays in constituting inquiry committees and the diversion of officers assigned to the investigations for other official duties as the primary reasons for prolonged inquiries.

SC directs Rajasthan to set up coordination group, commission to restore polluted rivers

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday directed the Rajasthan government to constitute, within seven days, an integrated coordination group headed by the Chief Secretary to implement its directions for restoring the Jojari, Bandi and Luni river system. It also ordered the creation of a river commission to oversee the conservation of rivers across the State.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta observed that material placed before the court by various stakeholders revealed severe degradation of the riverine ecosystem and illegal discharge of industrial effluents, warranting immediate intervention and a coordinated institutional response.

“The State of Rajasthan shall, within a period of seven days, constitute an ‘Integrated Coordination Group’ headed by the Chief Secretary,” the Bench ordered, adding that the group could include senior government officials, pollution control authorities and other experts.

The directions came in a suo motu proceeding initiated in September 2025 after the Apex Court took cognisance of reports of extensive pollution in the Jojari, Bandi and Luni rivers flowing through Jodhpur, Pali and Balotra districts, respectively. The court subsequently constituted a high-level commit-



The SC observed that material placed before the court by various stakeholders revealed severe degradation of the riverine ecosystem. FILE PHOTO

tee headed by former Rajasthan High Court judge Justice Sangeet Lodha to prepare a time-bound restoration plan for the river system.

Targets, timeline

The Bench directed the coordination group to consult the high-level committee and prepare a resolution plan within three weeks of its constitution, setting out responsibilities, targets and timelines. It also asked the group to use technologies such as satellite mapping and AI-based surveillance for environmental monitoring and enforcement.

Observing that bodies such as the Rajasthan River Basin and the Water Resources Planning Authority had become largely defunct and failed to effectively discharge their functions, the Bench directed the State to constitute a river commission headed by the Chief Secretary and comprising domain experts.

Horatti quits Council Chairperson position

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Legislative Council Chairperson Basavaraj Horatti submitted his resignation from the post on Friday, making way for the Congress to have one of its own members to preside over the Upper House.

The Congress has named its senior leader Saleem Ahmed as the candidate for the position. He is

expected to be officially anointed Chairperson on August 14. Until such time, Mr. Horatti would continue as pro-tem Speaker.

There had been several rounds of talks with Mr. Horatti on the issue, with Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar taking the lead in an effort to persuade him to resign of his own volition to avoid a no-confidence motion. The Congress has a majority in the 75-member Legislative Council.

CPI(M) flays halt of doorstep pensions

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government’s decision to stop doorstep in-person disbursal of social welfare pensions and channel the monthly payment of ₹2,000 through direct benefit transfer (DBT) to Aadhaar-linked bank accounts has run into strong political headwinds in Kerala.

Around 60 lakh people,

including the elderly, differently abled, widows, agricultural labourers and single women above 60, benefit from the social security allowance.

The CPI(M) has announced a large-scale mobilisation of pension beneficiaries against the move.

CPI(M) leader K.N. Balingopal said that he saw “an entrenched plot to ensnare the pension delivery system in red-tape” in order to undermine the scheme.

INBRIEF



Telangana govt. to perform vedic ritual for strong rains

A ‘Varuna Yagam’ will be performed at Nagarjunasagar on August 10, praying for widespread rains, abundant river flows and replenishment of reservoirs and tanks across Telangana, Irrigation and Civil Supplies Minister N. Uttam Kumar Reddy said. The special vedic ritual would be organised following a decision by Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy, who wanted the prayers to be offered for copious rainfall across the State and prosperity of farmers. The Yagam will be performed on the Vijaya Vihar premises on the banks of the reservoir.

Karnataka extends deadline for SIR enumeration phase

The enumeration phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), which was scheduled to end on Saturday, has been extended till August 17, the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Karnataka, announced on Friday. This is the second extension granted for the exercise. The draft electoral rolls, scheduled to be published on August 17, will now be released on August 24. The period for filing claims and objections is slated to run from August 24 to September 23, while the final electoral rolls will be published on October 27.

Karnataka pays Japanese man compensation over false case

Nearly seven years after arriving in Bengaluru to study English but instead finding himself entangled in a criminal case, an alleged police bribery and a prolonged legal battle, Japanese national Hirotooshi Tanaka has finally received ₹75,000 in compensation from the Karnataka government. The payment follows an order of the Karnataka State Human Rights Commission (KSHRC), which held that Mr. Tanaka had been unnecessarily kept in judicial custody for 19 days in 2019.

Spiritual offering



Seeking blessings: Devotees carrying milk pots and decorated kavadis participate in a religious procession on the occasion of Aadi Kirthugai at Sri Skandagiri Devasthanam in Secunderabad on Friday. G. RAMAKRISHNA

TDP leader killed in Kurnool; Minister vows stringent action

The Hindu Bureau
KURNOOL

Telugu Desam Party (TDP) leader Sheik Intiyaz Basha (35), was allegedly murdered following an altercation with a group of friends in Kurnool, Andhra Pradesh, on Thursday night.

According to the One-Town police, Intiyaz Basha, a resident of Old Basthi in Kurnool, had reportedly met some friends when an argument broke out among them. The altercation escalated, and one of the persons allegedly picked up a large stone and struck him on the head, killing him on the spot.

The police shifted the

body to the Government Medical College, Kurnool, for post-mortem. A case has been registered and an investigation is under way. As a precautionary measure, a police picket has been posted in the Old Basthi locality.

Minister for Industries T.G. Bharat Gupta expressed shock over the murder of the TDP leader on Friday.

Condemning the incident, he said the death of Intiyaz Basha was deeply distressing and assured the bereaved family of the party’s support. He said stringent action would be taken against those responsible for the crime.

‘AI sentries’ bring new hope to Kerala’s fight against human-wildlife conflict

Navamy Sudhish
KOLLAM

Marking a major leap in human-wildlife conflict management, an artificial intelligence (AI)-driven digital sentry system deployed across six high-risk forest zones in Kerala has achieved a near-100% success rate in repelling wild animals.

First piloted at Mankala, under the Paruthippally range in Thiruvananthapuram, the ‘Farmguard’ units were later expanded to five critical forest fringes in Kollam, Thrissur and Palakkad districts.

These units harness advanced machine learning, night-vision capabilities, and high-resolution came-



A screen grab shows the AI sentry system detecting an elephant at Kulathupuzha in Kollam district of Kerala. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ras to distinguish between living creatures and inanimate objects.

“Positioned along perimeter lines, multi-directional camera setups continuously scan a radius of up to around 200 metres. The moment a target animal such as an elephant,

wild boar, leopard, tiger, bear, or gaur steps into the monitored perimeter, the system’s integrated algorithms identify the specific species. It instantly triggers real-time alerts via SMS, WhatsApp, and Telegram to forest officials and Rapid Response Teams

the company’s efforts to strengthen India’s indigenous launch infrastructure and advance reusable launch capabilities.

The company added that it is also building the complete industrial chain required for launch – from engine manufacturing and high-flow testing to stage integration, vehicle qualification and launch operations.

“All critical propulsion design authority, system engineering, manufacturing knowledge, software and mission configuration will remain under Indian control. The next major milestone for the programme will be the full-engine hot-fire test...,” it said.

Astrobase unveils India’s first private 800kN rocket engine

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Astrobase, a Bengaluru-based space company unveiled India’s first privately built 800 kN Full-Flow Staged Combustion (FFSC) LOX-Methane rocket engine on Friday.

“The engine, named EVEREST, has been developed by Astrobase making it the fourth commercial company to successfully develop a high thrust flow FFSC engine globally,” said Neeraj Khandelwal, co-founder and CEO, Astrobase Space Technologies.

Astrobase Space Technologies said that the unveiling of EVEREST marks a significant milestone in



GROUND ZERO



Sakshi Chaudhary, Preeti Pawar, and Priya Ghanghas after winning gold medals in boxing at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Scotland. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Haryana’s golden girls

Four women from Haryana’s Bhiwani, known as India’s Mini Cuba of boxing, won gold at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. Their victories are especially significant in a district long associated with one of India’s most skewed sex ratios. **Ashok Kumar** traces their journeys of grit, the barriers they overcame, the people who inspired them, and how their success is reshaping attitudes towards girls

In the heart of Dhanana village, in Haryana’s Bhiwani district, where most houses have unplastered brick walls, one conspicuously stands out. It is a sprawling *kothi* or bungalow, just a stone’s throw away from the bus stop. A temple spire rises from its courtyard, reaching for the grey sky.

It is the overcast morning of August 4. Two days earlier, the curtains had come down on the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Scotland. Inside the *kothi*, there is no time to wait for the sun. Despite a light drizzle, two painters stand on ladders on opposite corners of the compound, brushes in hand. They have a day to complete their work. Sakshi Chaudhary is coming home, with a gold medal.

Inside the *baithak* (sitting room), there is plenty of commotion. Sakshi’s father, Manoj Dhanda, a farmer, is pacing, phone glued to his ear. He is trying to finalise a Haryana cabinet minister for the felicitation.

A few feet away, his friend Wazir Singh, a former serviceman, is negotiating with a local Ragini singer – a folk art form that blends poetry, storytelling, and music. Ticking off his list, he says, “500 chairs for the elders. Ladoos, jalebis, hot tea, coffee, and paneer pakoras for everyone.”

In the corner, Kaptan Ghanghas, a brick kiln owner, is multitasking. Shouting instructions to a man nearby, he says, “I want 150 banners. All up by tomorrow. I want the entire 20 kilometre-route [from Bhiwani city to Dhanana] covered.”

He then picks up his phone and asks in the same authoritative tone, “How many bikes? How many tractors? Talk to all the academies nearby. I need numbers.”

Hundreds of motorcycles, tractors, and cars have been arranged for the procession for Sakshi and Priya Ghanghas, also a gold medalist from the same village. Invitations have been sent to all 84 khap panchayats.

India’s record-breaking boxing campaign at the 2026 Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, which culminated in 10 medals – seven gold and three silver – was powered by an unlikely but familiar force: Bhiwani, popularly known as India’s Mini Cuba of boxing. Four of these gold medals were won by women nurtured in the town’s celebrated boxing culture: Sakshi Chaudhary (51 kg), Preeti Sai Pawar (54 kg), Jaismine Lamboria (57 kg), and Priya Ghanghas (60 kg).

A smiling Wazir sums up the mood: “Our daughters are our VIPs.”



Most of them in these villages want to escape poverty and make a name. That hunger is what drives Bhiwani boxing.

VIJENDER SINGH
Olympic medalist in boxing

Sitting quietly behind her husband, her face covered with a veil, Sakshi’s mother Sheila says that following her daughter’s career has taught her a surprising amount about boxing. “I know terms like knockout, charging, uppercut, and hook,” she says, shyly.

Sport has always been close to Sheila’s heart. As a teenager, she played kabaddi. Her father’s friend, the Haryana wrestler Chandgi Ram, tried to convince her family to allow her to take up wrestling, but they never agreed.

Today, Sheila feels that her own unfulfilled sporting dream has been realised through her daughter. “I’m just waiting to hug her,” she says, her voice choking with emotion.

Channeling the energy

Priya’s family eagerly awaits the return of the youngest of Haryana’s four women boxing gold medalists. The family recently moved from Dhanana to Dabra Colony in Bhiwani, where preparations to welcome their champion are in full swing. A cake sits ready on the table.

Her mother, Meera, recalls the emotional moment when she and her husband, Mahender, a stone crusher contractor, received Priya at Delhi’s Indira Gandhi International Airport in the early hours of August 4. “I had prepared *churma* (mashed up roti in ghee and jaggery) for her,” Meera says. “She was happy to eat it after returning home.”

According to her family, Priya and her elder brother Neeraj were so energetic and mischievous that their parents channelled their boundless energy into sport. “It turned out to be the best decision we made,” says Meera.

Bright, disciplined, and eager to learn, Priya impressed her coach immediately. Within just two days of training, the coach told the family that the girl had the potential to go far.

That prediction came true. At just 20, Priya has won a gold at the Commonwealth Games. Her success has also brought financial stability to the family, with Priya joining the Indian Railways in October 2025.

Meera says many talented athletes do not get the opportunities that her daughter received eventually. “There is little support before players become successful,” she says. “I know many talented children who had to quit boxing because their families simply couldn’t afford the expenses.



Gold medalist Jaismine Lamboria with her parents at their home in Bhiwani district of Haryana. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

es. The government helps only after a player wins major tournaments.”

The girls who bring glory

For a region long associated with one of India’s most skewed sex ratios, Bhiwani and neighbouring Charkhi Dadri are now telling a different story. In 2011, Bhiwani had 886 females per 1,000 males, compared with the national average of 943. Today, daughters are increasingly seen not as a burden, but as a source of pride.

“People are focusing more on their daughters than their sons,” says Sheila. “They have realised that girls can often achieve more if they are given the right opportunities. They can become doctors, engineers, and bring glory to the country through sports.” In contrast, she worries that many young boys are falling prey to drug addiction.

Few people have witnessed the change more closely than Kaptan, who credits Manoj with planting the seeds of a boxing revolution. “It was Sakshi’s father who convinced many families to send their daughters to the boxing ring,” he says. “This year, two girls from our village have become Commonwealth champions. In 2022, Nitu Ghanghas won gold at the 2022 Commonwealth Games. If our village is producing champions today, a large share of that credit belongs to him.”

Wazir says a public felicitation for Sakshi and the other champions is being planned to not just honour them, but also to inspire the next generation. “If these girls can do it, then the daughters of every family here can do it,” he says. “The message to parents is simple: support your daughters and give them every opportunity possible.”

Jagdish Singh, founder of the Bhiwani Boxing Club that produced Olympic medalist Vijender Singh and others, says every medal won by a female boxer attracts more girls to the sport. “After Nitu won the gold in 2022, the number of girls joining the club surged,” he says. “Vijender’s Olympic bronze was the first big turning point.”

At his club, boys and girls now train in nearly equal numbers. He also runs a hostel for 20 girls; 16 of them currently stay there.

Singh, who coached Sakshi, expects another spike after these Games. “More girls will now take up boxing as a career,” he says.

Vijender Singh says all the five Bhiwani gold medalists – four women and Sachin Siwach – are from nearby villages: Mittathal, Dhanana, and Badesara. “Most of them in these villages want to escape poverty and make a name. That hunger is what drives Bhiwani boxing,” he explains.

Family legacy

Jaismine Lamboria, the third woman gold medalist from Bhiwani, believes that the biggest challenge for many girls begins long before they step into a ring. “Unlike boys, who often simply inform their families about their ambitions, girls frequently have to seek permission to play, travel, and pursue their dreams,” she says. Social expectations and family concerns, she adds, can be



I know many talented children who had to quit boxing because their families simply couldn’t afford the expenses. The government helps only after a player wins major tournaments.

MEERA
Mother of Priya Ghanghas

barriers long before training even begins.

At the same time, she sees encouraging signs of change. “Families are becoming more supportive, women are receiving greater opportunities, and institutions are opening more doors for female athletes,” she says. These developments, she believes, show that the playing field is gradually becoming equal.

The first woman boxer to join the Indian Army, 25-year-old Jaismine comes from a family steeped in boxing. Her great-grandfather, Captain Hawa Singh, won the National Championships for 11 consecutive years, while her uncles, Sandeep and Parvinder, are international boxers.

When she first shared her ambition with her mother while in Class 8, the family had some concerns, but they never discouraged her. Her uncle convinced them that if athletes such as Sakshi Malik and P.V. Sindhu could bring glory to the country, Jaismine could do the same. With a coach in the family, her boxing journey took off.

But Jaismine’s rise was not smooth. Before the Commonwealth Games, she battled a prolonged illness that left her with recurring fever for weeks, disrupting her training and causing significant weight loss. She had little time to prepare for the competition. Yet, she fought her way to the final, where she defeated a seasoned former Commonwealth champion to claim gold. “For me, the focus was never on my opponent’s reputation but on giving my best in the ring,” she says.

She has a message for aspiring women boxers: “You are second to none. Choose your dream, keep moving forward, and never stop until you achieve it. Always remember, you are strong.”

Reluctant athlete

As a teenager, Preeti Sai Pawar wanted to focus on academics. She never imagined that boxing would become her life’s calling.

Preeti’s family moved from Badesara village in Bhiwani to Meham in Rohtak to provide better educational and training opportunities for their children. The daughter of a Haryana Police Assistant Sub-Inspector, Preeti initially resisted boxing despite constant encouragement from her father and her coach, Vinod Pawar.

“I kept telling my father that I would rather study,” she recalls. “The training was painful and my limbs would ache. But gradually, I started enjoying it.”

The turning point came in 2019 when she clinched her first gold medal at the school nationals. “That was when I realised that I wanted to pursue boxing seriously,” she says.

After winning bronze at the 2022 Asian Games and representing India at the Paris Olympics in 2024, she won a gold at the Asian Boxing Elite Championships in March 2026. At the Commonwealth Games, she showcased tactical maturity, dominating her Canadian opponent with aggressive yet calculated boxing. After comfortably winning the opening two rounds, she entered the final round with confidence, experimenting with new skills and sealing a comfortable victory.

Her performances have also earned her a rare distinction off the ring. Last December, Preeti became the first woman boxer to be directly recruited into the Indian Army as a Junior Commissioned Officer (naib subedar). “Representing the Army gives me immense pride,” she says.

Preeti is in the final year of her B.Sc. programme in Health and Physical Education at Lovely Professional University, which has supported her by facilitating online examinations during competitions.

The four women boxers have overcome unique challenges, but they now share one dream: to make it to the Los Angeles Olympics in 2028.

CM
YK

A ND-NDE

INBRIEF



Manipur ex-CM Biren Singh's audio clip altered, says Centre

The Supreme Court on Friday directed the Union government to share the latest report by the National Forensic Sciences University with the petitioner-NGO Kuki Organisation for Human Rights in a case seeking probe into the alleged involvement of former Manipur Chief Minister N. Biren Singh in the ethnic violence in the State. According to the report, the leaked audio clips alluding to Mr. Singh have been “clearly manipulated”. Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, representing both the Centre and the State of Manipur, said even the first-generation copy of the audio clippings outed by a whistleblower showed alterations. Advocate Prashant Bhushan, representing the petitioner, strongly objected to the report, saying tests of the audio clippings done at Truth Labs had shown a 93% match with Mr. Singh's voice.

Why should Jantar Mantar be used as protest site, asks HC

The Delhi High Court on Friday raised concerns over the continued use of Jantar Mantar as the designated venue for protests in Delhi, with Justice Amit Mahajan questioning whether public agitations should be held in the middle of the capital. “According to me, these things should not happen in the city,” Justice Mahajan said in oral remarks. The court was hearing a petition by the All India Dalit Christian Rights Protection Committee seeking a direction to the Delhi Police to decide on its request for permission to hold a peaceful protest at Jantar Mantar on August 10.

India formally names 27 places in Arunachal Pradesh on official map

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

In response to frequent attempts by China to rename some places in Arunachal Pradesh, India on Friday formally identified 27 places – including land, passes, a lake and a monument – in the border State by their standard names on the official Indian map. “Identifying them formally on the Survey of India map of Arunachal Pradesh is aimed at facilitating their accurate recognition and better awareness among the public at large,” the Union Home Ministry said in a statement. The 27 locations formally marked on the official map include Long Ju located along the Line of Actual Control, which was one of the earliest flashpoints between India and China in 1959 when Chinese forces entered the area.

The list also includes Bis-a village, a strategically important high-altitude mountain pass in the region. One of the most strategically important high-altitude passes, Thag La, where one of the opening battles between Indian and Chinese forces took place in 1962, has also been formally identified on the official map. “Baseless narratives” India has been dismissing Chinese efforts to assign “fictitious names” to Indian territory, asserting such attempts to create “baseless narratives” cannot alter “undeniable reality” and could derail efforts to normalise bilateral ties.

Meta ramps up censorship of protest, political reels

Instagram posts by party accounts, CJP representatives, ordinary protesters have been blocked in India; the action comes after the company held meetings with the government over past few days

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Posts by political leaders, parties, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) members, and ordinary protesters have started disappearing from Instagram at a rapid pace, following tense meetings between the company's leadership and the Union government. The Indian Youth Congress, Aam Aadmi Party convener Arvind Kejriwal, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das, and the news portal Scroll are among those whose posts have been blocked in India. Instagram's parent company, Meta, has been pressed in meetings about its recommendation algorithm, as the government zeroes in on the amplification of anti-establishment social media content as a factor leading up to last month's youth protests, which concluded with the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education Minister. Screenshots of posts blocked in India referred to the IT Rules, 2021, indicating that the posts are being censored through a take-down mechanism. While numerous reels – short video clips on Insta-



'Sahyog Portal puts in place a system to take down content online, without any of the safeguards present under Section 69A'. REUTERS

gram – remain available on Meta's platform, many have been removed, including some which have been watched millions of times. Many X users have reported that the protest-related content that remains on Instagram is now appearing less frequently.

'Against free speech' “What is this blanket ban on protest-related and Modi-related content?” the CJP's Mr. Das asked. “It is unconstitutional and illegal. It is absolutely ridiculous. We appeal to Meta to not succumb to such high-handed pressure from the government. Algorithms must moderate grossly illegal content, not police free expression. The entire point of free internet is this. Any social media platform doing this under pres-

sure is going against free speech principles and public interest.” Meta did not respond to a request for comment on this new wave of censorship. The government and police agencies had already ramped up censorship of Instagram posts in particular. X leaves up many posts that are reported to it under Section 79(3)(b), since these notices – unlike those under Section 69A of the IT Act, 2000 – do not entail criminal liability. However, as *The Hindu* reported on April 25, Meta complies automatically to such requests, giving the government vast powers of quick censorship. Pranesh Prakash, a co-founder of the Centre for Internet and Society and now a tech law and policy consultant, had then told

The Hindu that Meta's automatic compliance to Section 79(3)(b) notices was problematic, as platforms were only in the dock if and when a particular piece of content was taken to court, which happens rarely. “Yet, instead of fighting for their users, Meta is unthinkingly removing content it is legally not even required to remove,” Mr. Prakash had said. Those powers are now being exercised at an unprecedented rate, and affecting a broad range of content. An early viral clip, with over one crore views, featuring Students' Federation of India activist Sakhi mocking police announcements exhorting protesters to clear out of Jantar Mantar, has also been taken down. On August 6, several Facebook posts by Mr. Kejriwal were restricted. Many Section 79(3)(b) requests are filed to social media platforms through the Home Ministry's Sahyog portal. “The Sahyog Portal puts in place a parallel system to take down content online, without any of the safeguards present under Section 69A,” the Software Freedom Law Centre, India said in a statement on Thursday.



AISA president Neha Bora along with student demonstrators raise slogans during a protest march in Ranchi on Friday. PTI

Jharkhand govt. team holds discussion with protesting students

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

A delegation of the Jharkhand government, comprising Ministers, on Friday held talks for the first time in State capital Ranchi with student protesters demanding an inquiry by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) into alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs. The students' protest under the JPSS-JSCC Reform Manch entered the 14th day. The two-hour-long meeting, though, ended without any agreement with the students firm on continuing their protests. The five-member committee, comprising Ministers Sudivya Kumar, Chandra Linda, Dipika Pandey Singh and Sanjay Singh, along with Development Commissioner Ajay Kumar Singh, held discussions with a 10-member student

delegation at the State Guest House. After the meeting, student leader Ravindra Paswan said: “It was the first round of meeting and the government listened to our demands. However, we could not reach any conclusion regarding our key demands. Therefore, the protest will continue.” On the other hand, Education Minister Sudivya Kumar said, “The talks with the students took place in a positive atmosphere. All their points were heard and understood seriously, and the government will consider their demands before deciding on the next course of action.” During a protest march to the Jharkhand Assembly earlier in the day, a man splashed ink on All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha Bora. Later, he was detained by the police.

In Modi's outreach to Gen Z, parents are the key target

NEWS ANALYSIS

Varghese K. George
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has posted several reels on Instagram since July 23, in response to the student protests against his government in Delhi and many other parts of the country. RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat has also started addressing the youth of India. This was widely seen as a bold effort to reach out to the Instagram generation, or Gen Z, aged between 14 and 29. The oldest among them were one year shy of voting age in 2014, when Mr. Modi came to power; the youngest were two years old. A particular video of Mr. Modi, in which he offers forgiveness to young protesters who made vulgar remarks against him, has attracted wide public interest. He described

them as “misguided children”. Some see it as an act of magnanimity, while others see it as duplicity, considering the amount of vulgarity routinely mouthed by BJP affiliates. That leads us to the question of whom Mr. Modi is addressing through his new reel politics. Is he addressing Gen Z or their parents, the WhatsApp generation? It appears plausible that Mr. Modi, and the RSS chief, may not be trying to win over the Instagram generation, but rather to consolidate the WhatsApp generation, whose original support for the BJP is currently shaky. This outreach is guided by the wisdom of the patriarch that a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush. The idea is more to stop the unravelling of what the Sangh Parivar holds, and less to win over what it does not have. Mr. Modi and Mr. Bhagwat are



Narendra Modi

talking to fellow patriarchs more than to the protesters. What they are expressing is a combination of paternalistic responsibility and authority, rallying the parents of Gen Z, the stormtroopers of Hindutva. Mr. Modi's popularity was built on a network of WhatsApp communities in the run-up to 2014. There were around six crore Indians on WhatsApp then. It was through messages spread on that network that Mr. Modi's persona was built. The world view of the then aspirational

youth, broadly the parents of Gen Z, is a matter of detail, but suffice it to say that it broadly aligns with that of the BJP. **Two issues** There is little reason to think that they are revolting against Mr. Modi or his government, but there are two issues that have raised doubts in their minds about his performance, apart from the anxiety they share with their children regarding their education and employment. First, the embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya; and second, the snowballing concerns related to the mandatory blending of ethanol with petrol. Both these issues cut close to the bone for them: they are donors at Ayodhya, and they had associated their capacity to own a vehicle with the rise of Hindutva under Mr. Modi. This binds them in a com-

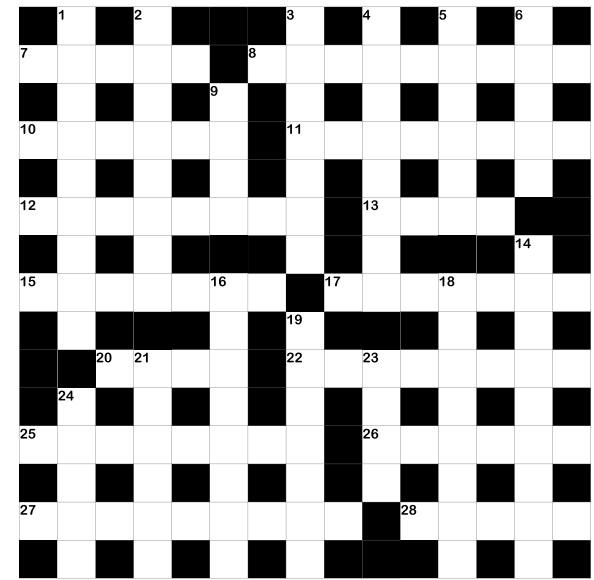
plicated relationship with Mr. Modi. Their loyalty is shaken, but they are not willing to choose anyone over Mr. Modi. Or any ideology over the Sangh's. Mr. Modi's reels are talking to them, saying: look, your “daughters” are using abusive language; it was a “cultural shock”; and we need to do something. We need to correct and guide them. They are nudged to consider what is of utmost urgency: donation theft in Ayodhya, the health of automobiles, or the cultural shock of defiant daughters. This is an age-old message repurposed for the digital era, the notion of *Kaliyuga* in Hindu tradition, which is always imagined in the present as a breach of social and gender hierarchy and order. Mr. Modi's message appears to be landing well among the segment it is addressed to. The WhatsApp generation, going by anecdotal examples one can

gather, is finding common cause with Mr. Modi in trying to ensure that their daughters are disciplined and cultured. It is routine for parents to expect their children to live by the rules that they themselves may not follow. For centuries, the family has been an arena of assertion and a site of negotiation with the state for all forms of religious politics in India. Mr. Modi is offering to lead community elders in taking control of the unruly, rebellious generation. Gen Z parents may even be willing to suspend their concerns regarding the Ayodhya embezzlement and ethanol blending. What appears as Gen Z outreach may be aimed more at their parents and other elders, conveying that the BJP is their natural shelter and is best suited to uphold their cultural values. It is about rallying the patriarchs rather than pacifying the protesters.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14867
(set by Mythical)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



13. Pet needs extra care, kindness for starters (4)
15. Leaves saint South African currency notes finally (7)
17. Does poor saint occasionally put money in bank ? (7)
20. Mark to work with gangster (4)
22. Wind and rain with sleet bothered staff inside (8)
25. Find night club closed, promoters essentially missing (8)
26. 5 in vehicle held back by boxer cycling (6)
27. Hosting a show on the radio, examining similarities and differences (9)
28. This little tie adjusted, I'm all set! (5)
- DOWN
1. Control Utah riot somehow before end of day (9)
2. Posh male — British, getting jazz singer Fitzgerald handy device (8)
3. Some take a siesta, most comfortable (7)
4. Reach princess held up by security team initially near a new church (8)
5. A girl opts out of teaching troubled folk (6)
6. The advisory group we gathered, is uninterested (5)
9. In retrospect, say Germany has the upper hand (4)
14. Doctor Victor, I'll try hiring union agent at first for all practical purposes (9)
16. Releases revolutionary despised by society (8)
18. Discover comedian's somewhat lost for words (8)
19. That man leading a group investigation? (7)
21. Engage people (6)
23. Lacking money ultimately, want to get paid (4)
24. Firstly, woman's in distress, often weeping — her partner's gone (5)

- ACROSS
7. One with issue that's kept under wraps (5)
8. Going back, help a rabbi to avoid reportedly toxic emission (9)
10. Inane speech by revolutionary outside a joint (6)
11. One new model completed as planned (8)
12. Online troublemakers blocked by expert youths — initially, they might get pushed around (8)

SUDOKU

2						9		
		9					2	6
	7	6			3		4	
	8			9		6		2
	9		1		6		8	
7		1		8			9	
	5		2			1	6	
1	2					8		
		4						7

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH
Garuda, Desika relationship

The relationship between Garuda, the divine mount of Lord Vishnu, and Swami Vedanta Desika, one of the most prominent Acharyas in the Sri Vaishnava tradition, is narrated in a discourse by Sri Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar. Just as Garuda serves as the mount transporting the Supreme Lord, Acharyas such as Desika carry the wisdom of the Vedas to uplift human beings from worldly binding (*samsara*). The glory of Garuda is expounded, including his incarnation as the embodiment of the Vedas, and how his grace led to Desika's profound compositions. Garuda is revered as Vedatma, the soul embodiment of the Vedas. His two wings symbolise the Vedic meters and chants. Swami Alavandar beautifully summarises how Garuda performs every form of *kainkaryam* (selfless divine service) to Lord Narayana. *Garutman* is *daasaha*: (the devoted servant), *sakha* (the beloved friend), *vahanam* (the Lord's divine vehicle), *asanam* (His seat or throne), *dhwajaha*: (His flag or banner), and *vyajanam* (the ceremonial fan used in divine worship). Desika received the initiation (*Upadesam*) of the Garuda Mantra from his guru Kidambi Appullar. Desika travelled to Tiruvaheendrapuram and meditated on the Aushadhagiri Hill. Desika chanted the Garuda Mantra, and Garuda appeared before him, blessed him by bestowing the sacred Hayagreeva Mantra, and presented him with an idol of Lord Hayagreeva (horse-faced deity of knowledge). To express gratitude to Garuda, Desika composed Garuda Dandakam. The spiritual and physical benefits of reciting the Garuda Dandakam are protection against poison, snake bites, and harmful energies. It eradicates fear, anxiety, and mental obstructions.



Dabur India Ltd., which was directed by FSSAI earlier this week to withdraw some of its products with the “100%” label, has secured a stay on the order from the Delhi High Court. “It is now submitted that the Hon’ble Delhi High Court has today i.e. on August 07, 2026, granted stay against the aforesaid prohibitory order of FSSAI dated August 03, 2026,” Dabur India said in a filing with the exchanges. “Any material update in the matter will be intimated to the stock exchanges in due course of time,” it added.

Hindalco Industries Ltd. of the Aditya Birla Group, for the quarter ended June 30, 2026, reported a 75% YoY growth in consolidated net profit at ₹7,013 crore driven by strong momentum in its India business and recovery at subsidiary Novelis. Novelis recorded a 37% improvement in EBITDA at ₹4,875 crore, due to the successful restart of Oswego hot mill and accelerated benefits from its cost optimisation programme, the company said.

Hero MotoCorp Ltd. has reported a 16.86% fall in consolidated profit after tax to ₹1,417.93 crore in the first quarter ended June 30 due to high base effect. The company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹1,705.65 crore in the corresponding period of the previous fiscal. The previous year PAT included a one-time gain of ₹722 crore on account of dilution of the company's share of investment in associates consequent to public issue and private placement, the firm said. PTI

Months after cutting almost 27% of global routes in response to soaring fuel costs, Air India will restore most international services from September 1 and add frequencies on several key long-haul routes.



AI would also add frequencies on key long haul routes.

Additional frequencies

"Though fuel prices remain higher than before the Middle East conflict and remain volatile, they have moderated from their initial peak, so as well as the restorations we will be adding additional frequencies," Al chief executive officer Campbell Wilson wrote to employees.

Though the restored schedule is yet to be formally announced, Air India had said in May, that it was suspending 145 weekly international flights between June and August, affecting routes across North America, Europe, South-east Asia, SAARC and the Far East.

Overall Electric Vehicles (EV) retail sales in July surged 66% year-on-year (YoY) to 3,27,901 units and with this, almost one in eight vehicles retailed are now electric, as per Federation of Automobile Dealers Association (FADA).

In July, e-two-wheeler retail sales crossed two-lakh for the first time to 2,04,362 units, up 88% with a market share of 11.2% from 7.7% a year earlier. The segment was led by TVS Motor which sold 55,499 units, up 13%.



EVs logged record sales in July.

60.3% a year ago. As many as 87,055 units of e-three wheelers were retailed which was a growth of 25.3% with this segment led by Mahindra Group which reported retail sales of 14,191 units, up 45%.

E-three-wheelers secured 65.1% share, up from 58.1% in 2017. Electric commercial vehicles secured 14.1% share, up from 11.1% in 2017.

Oil marketing companies base their assurance on E20's reliability after checks across retail outlets, refineries, and at distilleries; also refute claims of excess moisture in the ethanol blended petrol

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

State-owned oil marketing companies (OMCs) on Friday rejected claims of chloride contamination in E20 fuel, stating that additional intensive testing conducted at retail outlets, refineries, and at the point of ethanol procurement confirmed that chloride levels remained within the prescribed limits.

In a joint statement, IndianOil, Bharat Petroleum and Hindustan Petroleum also refuted allegations of excess moisture in the one-fifth ethanol blended petrol fuel validated from water-ingress testing.

“Contrary to certain as-
sertions being made, based



'Clean' chit: The OMCs said 100 random petrol samples taken from varied refineries tested for "consistently low" chloride content. AP

on extensive random testing through scientifically designed tests, the evidence shows that there is no cause for any alarm on fuel contamination," they said in the statement.

The assurance from the OMCs comes days after the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM),

in a communication to the oil ministry, flagged concerns about vehicular parts experiencing wear due to excess chloride presence since the introduction of E20 petrol.

SIAM had later withdrawn the letter assuring that E20 was safe, emphasising the data they cited

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India's forex reserves jumped by \$10.512 billion to \$692.866 billion during the week ended July 31, the RBI said on Friday. The overall kitty had jumped by \$6.118 billion to \$682.354 billion in the previous reporting week.

Reserves had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the

week ended February 27 of this year before the onset of the West Asia conflict, which led to several weeks of drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales.

For the week ended July 31, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, increased by \$8.75 billion to \$ 564.68 billion, the central bank's da-

ta showed. Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

It may be recalled that the central bank and the government had launched a series of measures to attract more forex flows into the country last month, including FCNR(B).

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The U.S. has “today” become India’s largest supplier of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), accounting for 67% of its LPG imports, said Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri.

Addressing the CII International Energy Conference, he said the shift follows an earlier decision to



Hardeep Singh Puri

source roughly 10% of India's LPG requirements from the U.S. as part of a broader effort to diversify

energy supplies. "Some of us wondered would we need the 10% [from U.S.] when we have suppliers nearby [in the Gulf]. Today, I am happy to inform that U.S. accounts for about 67% of our LPG imports," he said. Separately, he refuted reports that the government proposed to impose an additional charge on LPG and natural gas to fund a strategic fuel reserve.

CM
YK

Smash, bang, whimper: the rise and fall of Bazball

Now that the most discussed and debated style of playing Test cricket since Bodyline has ended, how do we assess its legacy? What worked and what didn't? Could it have lasted longer? And how will it be remembered?

P.K. Ajith Kumar

The end came swiftly. It took New Zealand only 51.2 overs to wrap up the England second innings at Trent Bridge. Jamie Smith's slog against Mitchell Santner ended in the hands of a diving Nathan Smith, running in from long-on. That was not just the end of the third Test. It was also the end of what was perhaps the most discussed, or debated, style of playing Test cricket since Bodyline.

Breaking point

New Zealand won by 160 runs, and also became the first team ever to win a three-match series in England after losing the opening Test. It was indeed a fabulous achievement by Tom Latham's men.

For Latham's English counterpart, Ben Stokes, it was his last international match. For the coach, Brendon McCullum, it was the last Test in charge of England.

But for Bazball, we would not have witnessed Bairstow metamorphosing into Richards in 2022 or Pope turning the reverse sweep into the best form of defence in Hyderabad

Bazball thus came to its inevitable end. Ironically, it had begun with a series against New Zealand in an English summer, four years ago. And it had begun in magnificent fashion, with England winning four Tests, all chasing, all with guns blazing, in a row – three against New Zealand and one against India.

It was even more remarkable because the England Test team was going through a tough period at that time: it had won just one of 17 matches after the first Test against India at Chennai in early 2021. Coach Chris Silverwood lost his job, following the 0-4 drubbing in the 2021-22 Ashes in Australia, and after the defeat in the Caribbean in March 2022, Joe Root resigned.

So, it wasn't the most ideal of situations when McCullum was appointed as England's Test coach by Rob Key, managing director of England men's cricket. And the Kiwi had no previous experience of coaching in red-ball cricket, though he had been in charge of franchise teams such as the Kolkata Knight Riders.

McCullum conceived, Stokes executed. They will be remembered as one of cricket's most remarkable coach-captain duos. Their approach to playing Test



GETTY IMAGES

Bazball could perhaps have lasted longer if England had realised that Test cricket's charm lies in its infinite variety

cricket was the kind that hadn't been witnessed before. New Zealand and India weren't prepared for the ultra-aggressive mode of cricket England played in the summer of 2022.

It was not just England's style that was spectacular. The results were, too.

Against New Zealand, England's scores in the second innings were 279 for five, 299 for five, and 296 for three. Against India, it was 378 for three. And those chases were completed at brisk strike-rates.

Chasing a big total has always been a daunting task in Test cricket. Safety first has nearly always been the mantra, and even that stunning chase by India against Australia at Brisbane in 2021 had begun on a cautious note. It took an extraordinary hook by Washington Sundar against Pat Cummins and an out-of-the-world counterattacking knock by Rishabh Pant to make India shift gears and aim for the ultimate glory.

Interestingly, Stokes once spoke of how the manner in which Pant played made him think about the possibilities of aggressive batting in Test cricket. And before Pant, there were Adam Gilchrist and Virender Sehwag, but what made the concept of Bazball different was that everyone wanted to bat as if there was no tomorrow. If a wicketkeeper as accomplished as Ben Foakes could not find a place in the eleven, it showed what McCullum and Stokes wanted.

Finding expression

What Bazball looked to do was to remove the fear of failing. So regardless of the situation, a player was allowed to play his strokes, or express him-

self, as England cricketers would explain in press conference after press conference. When England fielded, the bowlers were asked to always look for wickets; restricting the batters from making runs wasn't the priority.

And England wanted to win. An exciting – though not successful – chase was found more appealing than a draw. One was never sure if that was quite right in competitive sport. And one of the charms of Test cricket – and also what someone new to cricket would not understand – is the sheer thrill of not getting a decisive result after playing for five days, more than 30 hours.

Such trivial matters, however, didn't cross the minds of the English players, and their fans, for much of the early part of the Bazball era, as the team posted some astounding wins, like the one against Pakistan at Rawalpindi in 2022, when England scored 657 from just 101 overs. Two years later, the victory against India in the first Test at Hyderabad was even greater, as England had conceded a first-innings lead of 190.

The four Tests that followed, however, showed why Bazball can't work all the time. India won all those matches. For all England's aggressive intent, it is debatable whether a batter of Root's quality needed to



play a reverse scoop against a bowler of Jasprit Bumrah's quality.

An identical scoreline (4-1) in the most recent Ashes in Australia meant that Bazball couldn't click against stronger opposition. Bazball also worked more on flatter surfaces, while it had problems when the ball moved or turned.

Right from the beginning of Bazball, the big question was whether it was a sustainable model. As former England batter Mark Butcher told *The Hindu* recently, Test cricket is a format that dictates to you what is necessary. "If you push too hard, the game will bite you back," he said.

McCullum and Stokes had indeed pushed too hard. When you go on to lose a Test match by two wickets after declaring on the opening day with two wickets remaining, questions are bound to be asked.

Questions were also asked about how some of the England players behaved off the field during the Bazball era. The pub-incident involving Stokes and Gus Atkinson this summer didn't help, either.

The statistics may not say that England benefited much from Bazball. In 49 Tests, England scored 27 wins, but lost 20. That there were just two draws is of course hardly surprising.

But it would not be fair to evaluate Bazball's legacy just based on numbers, even if they are impressive when it comes to run-rates, strike-rates and hundreds. It was an attempt to play Test cricket in a different way and entertain the paying public.

Fun while it lasted

But for Bazball, we would not have been able to witness Jonny Bairstow metamorphosing into Viv Richards in 2022 or Ollie Pope turning the reverse sweep into the best form of defence during his monumental 196 in the Hyderabad Test. Bazball was fun while it lasted.

It could have lasted longer perhaps if England had been a little more conservative on occasion and realised that Test cricket's charm lies in its infinite variety. There is more than one way to play what is the most demanding form of all sports.

There is joy in watching Harry Brook dance down the track. There is also joy in watching Shubman Gill play a perfect forward defensive push.



HARRY BROOK

STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	24	13,450	16
2	Carlos Alcaraz	23	8,160	16
3	Alexander Zverev	29	8,120	19
4	Felix Auger-Aliassime	25	4,740	22
5	Novak Djokovic	39	3,760	15
6	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,620	22
7	Alex de Minaur	27	3,560	23
8	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,330	25
9	Taylor Fritz	28	2,320	21
10	Ben Shelton	23	2,680	21
11	Alexander Bublik	29	2,535	25
12	Jiri Lehecka	24	2,380	20
13	Lorenzo Musetti	24	2,375	21
14	Casper Ruud	27	2,345	21
15	Rafael Jodar	19	2,243	23

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 235 ▲ 11 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 362 ▲ 10 spots



F1 Drivers' standings

#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	219	6
2	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	169	1
3	G. Russell	Mercedes	160	2
4	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	138	1
5	L. Norris	McLaren	128	1
6	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	109	0
7	O. Piastri	McLaren	92	0
8	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	68	0
9	L. Lawson	RB	43	0
10	P. Gasly	Alpine	42	0
11	A. Lindblad	RB	23	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	19	0
13	O. Bearman	Haas	18	0
14	G. Bortoleto	Audi	10	0
15	C. Sainz	Williams	6	0
16	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
17	E. Ocon	Haas	3	0
18	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	2	0
19	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	1	0
20	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
21	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
22	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0



A.K. Antonelli



L. Hamilton



Badminton Men's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	Shi Yu Qi	94,255	12
2	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	91,215	16
3	Jonatan Christie	89,231	17
4	Anders Antonsen	87,705	17
5	Christo Popov	87,002	20
6	Chou Tien Chen	84,280	27
7	Victor Lai	77,045	19
8	Lin Chun-Yi	71,274	19
9	Li Shi Feng	70,483	16
10	Alex Lanier	70,215	16
11	Kodai Naraoka	70,030	20
12	Alwi Farhan	69,419	19
13	Loh Kean Yew	66,300	20
14	Lakshya Sen	65,573	21
15	Toma Junior Popov	62,697	20

Top Indians ▶



Lakshya Sen
Rank 14



Ayush Shetty
Rank 23



Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Travis Head	853	884
2	Harry Brook	852	898
3	Joe Root	840	932
4	Steve Smith	831	947
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Kamindu Mendis	744	784
7	Shubman Gill	743	807
8	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
9	Yashasvi Jaiswal	733	858
10	Dinesh Chandimal	713	755

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Jasprit Bumrah	870	908
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Mitchell Starc	838	852
4	Pat Cummins	832	914
5	Marco Jansen	825	825
6	Scott Boland	820	820
7	Noman Ali	809	853
8	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
9	Josh Hazlewood	775	864
10	Nathan Lyon	753	812



WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Aryna Sabalenka	28	8,550	18
2	Elena Rybakina	27	8,056	21
3	Jessica Pegula	32	6,300	18
4	Coco Gauff	22	5,649	18
5	Mirra Andreeva	19	5,293	20
6	Karolina Muchova	29	5,168	20
7	Linda Noskova	21	5,016	21
8	Iga Swiatek	25	4,539	19
9	Amanda Anisimova	24	4,353	15
10	Elina Svitolina	31	4,351	16
11	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,925	16
12	Victoria Mboko	19	3,520	21
13	Naomi Osaka	28	3,086	17
14	Belinda Bencic	29	2,845	18
15	Jasmine Paolini	30	2,783	19

Top Indians ▶



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 343 ▲ 6 spots



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 382 ▲ No change



F1 Constructors' standings

Pos	Team	Points	Wins
1	Mercedes	379	8
2	Ferrari	307	2
3	McLaren	220	1
4	Red Bull	177	0
5	RB	66	0
6	Alpine	61	0
7	Haas	21	0
8	Audi	12	0
9	Williams	11	0
10	Aston Martin	1	0
11	Cadillac	0	0



Badminton Women's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	An Se Young	1,17,787	15
2	Akane Yamaguchi	1,04,576	18
3	Wang Zhi Yi	1,02,689	16
4	Chen Yu Fei	91,451	15
5	Han Yue	77,038	14
6	Putri Kusuma Wardani	76,473	18
7	Ratchanok Intanon	74,606	20
8	Tomoka Miyazaki	68,106	22
9	P.V. Sindhu	67,601	14
10	Pornpawee Chochuwong	66,727	16
11	Nozomi Okuhara	60,310	18
12	Kim Ga Eun	59,731	16
13	Michelle Li	55,227	21
14	Sim Yu Jin	55,084	10
15	Line Christophersen	54,060	21

Top Indians ▶



P.V. Sindhu
Rank 9



Unnati Hooda
Rank 26



ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	801	841
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	767	908
4	Rohit Sharma	758	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	712	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Harry Tector	679	730
8	Joe Root	674	810
9	Shai Hope	673	782
10	Charith Asalanka	659	705

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	682	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Jofra Archer	649	682
4	Keshav Maharaj	645	737
5	Mitchell Santner	644	656
6	Maheesh Theekshana	641	680
7	Bernard Scholtz	610	631
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	602	722
10	Adil Rashid	599	671

B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

How Miss Giggles is laughing her way to the top

Anahat Singh recently became the first Indian squash player to be crowned Junior World champion. How did the 'very chilled', 'happy-go-lucky kid' conquer the might of Egypt? And what does the future hold for the 18-year-old who reads opponents and situations better than most?



Coming into the [World Junior championships], I knew it was my last chance and how much it meant to check it off my list. That made a huge difference. It pushed me to give it my all

ANAHAT SINGH



CMYK A ND-NDE

PRECAUTIONARY MEASURE

Captain Gill skips opening day of practice game against SLC XI



FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

India captain Shubman Gill did not take the field on the opening day of the practice match against SLC XI in Colombo on Friday after sustaining an injury to his right finger during practice. Gill picked up the niggle during a training session on Thursday, and as a result, K.L. Rahul led the side in his absence.

SOLID SUPPORT

Both Rohit and Kohli will add value in the World Cup: Dhawan



GETTY IMAGES

Former India opener Shikhar Dhawan expressed confidence in Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli and backed them for the 2027 ODI World Cup. “They are legends and have performed for the country for so many years. And I’m sure that both of them will add value in the World Cup and help the team win,” Dhawan said.

HIGH PRAISE

Like me, but better: McCullum on new England Test coach Fleming



FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

Brendon McCullum has hailed his successor Stephen Fleming, *in pic.*, as “like me, but better”, after England appointed his former New Zealand teammate as Test coach. “I had a great time for those four years and now it’s heading in a different direction. Flem will be excellent. He’s a little bit like me, but better”.

NEXT ASSIGNMENT

Rahane joins European T20 league after phone call from Steve Waugh



FILE PHOTO

Ajinkya Rahane said he will play in the inaugural European T20 Premier League, thanks to a call from Steve Waugh. “The moment I took the call of retirement, within five minutes, Waugh called and asked, ‘Are you interested in playing for me,’” Rahane said. Waugh is the co-founder and Chief Cricket Officer of Amsterdam Flames.

Dominant Praggnanandhaa makes the winning moves at St. Louis

His maiden triumph in the prestigious event helps the Indian jump to second place in GCT standings; the Grandmaster says he is happy with the quality of his play; Sindarov finishes runner-up, So takes third place

CHESS

Press Trust of India
ST. LOUIS (USA)

Indian Grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa clinched his maiden Saint Louis Rapid and Blitz title in emphatic fashion, sealing the championship with a round to spare. The 20-year-old finished with 23.5 points, comfortably ahead of Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan, one of the contenders for the world championship cycle. The final round game between the duo ended in a draw. Not losing any games on the final day of the last rapid and blitz in the Grand Chess Tour (GCT) event, Praggnanandhaa jumped to second spot in the GCT which almost guarantees a place in the grand finale scheduled later this year. The Indian will just have to keep up his form in the last tournament of the season which will be played under the Classical system.



Dream run: Consistency did the trick for Praggnanandhaa in a strong field. FLICKR/GRANDCHESSTOUR

After winning the rapid section with a marginal lead against Sindarov, Pragg lost only one game in the blitz and scored the requisite victories to end up with 11.5 points out of a

possible 18.

Sindarov, who was trailing Praggnanandhaa by a full point after the rapid section, had to be content with the second spot on 22 points while Wesley So of

United States came third, scoring 20.5 points overall. Praggnanandhaa jumped to second spot in the overall GCT rankings following his triumph and much would depend on

how he performs in the last tournament slated to start on the weekend.

“I am super happy with the result (winning the St Louis Rapid & Blitz) and overall about the game quality.

“This is the first major rapid and blitz victory, so I’m really happy about it,” Praggnanandhaa posted on X after the triumph in the elite 10-man field.

“I want to thank my whole team and family for their amazing support. Next I’ll play in the Sinquefeld Cup, which will start in three days. So, there is not much time to rest and it’s also the event before the GCT final. It’s going to be really exciting,” the young Grandmaster added.

Final standings: 1. R Praggnanandhaa 23.5 points; 2. Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 22; 3. Wesley So (USA) 20.5; 4. Levon Aronian (USA) 19; 5-7. Fabiano Caruana (USA); Lenier Dominguez Perez (USA), Jorden Van Foreest (Ned) 17 each; 8. Anish Giri (Ned) 15.5; 9. Vincent Keymer (Ger) 14.5; 10. Awnerder Liang (USA) 14.

We don’t have the one thing that we desperately want: Mandeep

HOCKEY

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

When the Indian men’s hockey team takes the field on August 15 for its World Cup opener at the historic Wagener Stadium in the Netherlands, two experienced pros will be rewriting records and hoping to end more than half a century of disappointment for the country. Alongside teammate Manpreet Singh, 31-year-old Mandeep Singh will join an elite list of Indians to play four World Cups, previously achieved by legends Dhanraj Pillay and P.R. Sreejesh. Mandeep will also become the youngest to do so. He admits pride in the achievement but is also constantly reminded of the missing piece in his medal cabinet. “Of course, it feels great to play my fourth World Cup, a very proud moment. But it is also a reminder that there is nothing to show for the three I have already played. It’s just been participation so far... we don’t have the one thing that we so desperately want,” Mandeep told *The Hindu* ahead of the World Cup. For someone who has a medal from every other major competition in the sport, at every level - junior and senior Asia Cups,



Seasoned pro: Mandeep will be playing in his fourth World Cup. FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, Asian Champions Trophy and the Olympics - that empty space on his medal cabinet is a constant reminder of an unfinished job. “My father said the same thing when I spoke to him - you are still one short. But if this is the last chance for us, we won’t waste it and try to bring back that medal. It is a huge motivation, playing the fourth World Cup. Dhanraj sir did it, now we are going to do it. The dream now is to lift that cup,” he insisted. As one of the seniormost players in the side with 288 international matches under his belt, Mandeep is aware of his role but insists on collective responsibility. “I believe all 18 players in a team have to play; everyone is aware of their indi-

vidual responsibility and team target. Everyone has to perform; a senior or junior is just a tag that doesn’t matter on the field,” he explained. A chance to write his name in the history books is motivation enough. “When we won an Olympic medal in Tokyo after 41 years and then again in Paris, we saw how it completely changed Indian hockey’s stature and again gained recognition. “The wait for a World Cup medal has been longer, 51 years! So we are aware of its importance and what it would mean for the game and for the country. Which is why we are not even thinking of the Asian Games or anything else at the moment; full focus is on the World Cup,” he declared. The top two teams from

Baskaran hopeful of India’s prospects in the World Cup

Tarun Shastri
CHENNAI

India’s Olympic gold medal-winning captain V. Baskaran believes the current team is well prepared for the Hockey World Cup to be held in Belgium and the Netherlands from August 15. Speaking on the sidelines of the renaming and relaunch of the Hockey Tiruvallur as Tamil Hockey League, the 75-year-old backed the side coached by Craig Fulton. “I feel India is the best-prepared team. I think it is a balanced side. We have two players appearing in their fourth World Cup, six or seven in their third, a couple in their second, and six or seven making their debut. Even those debutants have played 20 to 25 international games, especially in Europe, and have enough exposure. I don’t see any weak link,” Baskaran said. “Overall, I believe the team is in safe hands. The forwards have to convert their chances, the midfield has to keep creating opportunities, the defenders must avoid major errors... the biggest positive is that both our goalkeepers (Mohith H.S. & Suraj Karkera) are in very good form,” he reckoned. The top two teams from



Baskaran. FILE PHOTO: AKHILA EASWARAN

I feel India is the best-prepared team. Overall, I believe the team is in safe hands

each of the four pools advance to the next stage. Baskaran, who led the country to the top of the podium in the 1980 Moscow Games, said the second round would be crucial. “The second round will be the real test. Beyond that, it is anybody’s tournament. There has been a long drought (since Ajit Pal Singh’s men triumphed in 1975), but I believe India can do well in this World Cup and progress past the pool stage. Pakistan will be competitive, but India should beat Wales. England will play cautiously and not take unnecessary risks. It should be a good tournament for India”.

India fights back after young Lankan batters excel on opening day

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

Press Trust of India
COLOMBO

The Indian bowling unit got some rough treatment from Sri Lanka’s Gen-Next batters before the spinners led by Kuldeep Yadav scripted a recovery in the final session as the host posted 363 for eight to end its first innings on the opening day of the three-day warm-up game here on Friday.

Since the match doesn’t have First Class status, each team will bat a maximum of 90 overs on days one and two and 45 overs each on the final day.

Off-spinner Saransh Jain, who went for 54 in his 11 overs, found the going tough. However, both Kuldeep (two for 76 in 18 overs) and Manav Suthar (two for 33 in 13 overs) did well.

The seasoned Ravindra Jadeja (two for 64 in 15 overs) looked out of sync despite getting a couple of wickets.

Playing a red-ball game after five weeks, the pacers were understandably rusty while the spinners, despite sharing the bulk of the spoils, didn’t look menacing enough till Kuldeep found his mojo and asked a few probing questions.

Otherwise, the day primarily belonged to the young island batters. They looked at ease while facing the Indian attack on a mostly benign Nondescripts Cricket Club track which provided some purchase for Kuldeep towards the fag end of the day. Two Sri Lankan batters stood out on the day. The first one was opener Nishan Fernando (66, 65b, 11x4, 1x6), who played the senior Indian pacers – Mohammed Siraj (none for



Bending his back: Gurnoor was the pick of the Indian pacers. X@BCCI

Fans will be allowed free entry during Sri Lanka’s two-Test series against India, starting August 15 in Galle, the country’s cricket board announced on Friday. The first match will be held at the Galle International Stadium while the second game will be held at the SSC in Colombo from August 23-27

44 in 13 overs), and Prasidh Krishna (none for 32 in eight overs) – with ease. Gurnoor Brar (one for 49 in 12 overs) was the only pacer who looked incisive. Fernando had recently played Tests on the West Indies tour. The 110-run opening stand with Ravindu Rasantha (71, 143b, 6x4, 1x6) had Indian pacers and

spinners scurrying for cover as they scored runs at a quick clip before an unfortunate mix-up led to Fernando’s run-out. The second one was southpaw Sonal Dinusha (52, 72b, 5x4, 1x6), who displayed admirable technique and the only batter in the middle-order who read Kuldeep from the wrist and hit a regal straight six. The SLC XI skipper had scored 92 against West Indies in a Test match recently. **The scores:** Sri Lanka Cricket XI 363/8 in 90 overs (Nishan Fernando 66, Ravindu Rasantha 71, Sonal Dinusha 52) vs. India. **Toss:** SLC XI.

AITA caps upper age limit for EC members at 70

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

The All India Tennis Association (AITA) has capped the upper age limit for its Executive Committee members at 70. At the Extraordinary General Meeting (EGM) held on July 26 to adopt the new constitution, there were sharp divisions on whether to keep it at 70 as mandated by the National Sports Governance Act or raise it to 75 by taking cover under the International Tennis Federation’s constitution which is silent on a ceiling. So tight was the vote at



Anil Khanna. FILE PHOTO: AKHILESH KUMAR

the AITA EGM that the final result was withheld until full scrutiny. It emerged on Friday, via an internal communication sent by interim president Chintan Parikh, that 25 votes were cast to

keep it at 70 years against 22 for 75. A prospective EC member now has to be less than 70 years on the date of filing the nomination but can complete a full term of four years even if he or she turns 70 any time after. This rules out veteran administrator Anil Khanna’s return, for he is 73. Parikh will turn 70 in the near future, and September 30 is the deadline for holding fresh elections under the new constitution. The AITA has to submit the finalised constitution to the Delhi High Court ahead of the next hearing in the matter on August 14.

INBRIEF



Khalin wins J&K Open in commanding style

Khalin Joshi carded a five-under 66 to complete a commanding nine-shot victory at the J&K Open, held at the Royal Springs Golf Course in Srinagar. The 33-year-old finished with a total of 260 (63-66-65-66) to claim his eighth professional title and second victory of the 2026 DP World PGTI season. Rashid Khan (68-68-64-69) finished runner-up while Shubham Jaglan (70-68-66-66) produced his best result of the season by finishing third at 270.

Titli Maji bags silver in Asian youth & junior weightlifting

Titli Maji clinched the women's 45kg category silver on the opening day of the Asian youth & junior weightlifting championships in Tashkent, Uzbekistan. Titli lifted 65kg in snatch and 80kg in clean and jerk.

Ariha wins historic gold at Asian Aerobic Gymnastics

Ariha Pangambam has become the first Indian to win a gold medal in the senior women's individual event of the Aerobic Gymnastics Asian Championships. Ariha topped the podium with a score of 19.1 with 8.65 for artistry, 7.6 for execution and 2.85 for difficulty.

Friday's DPL fixtures abandoned due to rain

Rain played spoilsport in the Delhi Premier League on Friday as both fixtures were abandoned. No play was possible in the afternoon encounter between East Delhi Riders and West Delhi Lions as well as in the meeting between Outer Delhi Warriors and North Delhi Strikers later in the evening. A number of matches have already been curtailed due to rain in the third edition, which will compel the Delhi & District Cricket Association to ponder about the scheduling of the T20 league going forward. Following the two washouts, Warriors are second in the standings with five points from four matches while North Delhi, which has three points after three games, is fifth. Lions, third in the table, have earned five points so far. East Delhi received its first point after three straight losses.

LIVE TELECAST

TNPL: Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official YouTube Channel (youtube@tamilnadupremierleague.com), 3.30 & 7.30 p.m.
Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 4 & 7 p.m.

Ashmita and Rakshitha in semifinal showdown

Press Trust of India
ASAN (SOUTH KOREA)

Ashmita Chaliha and Rakshitha Ramraj will square off in the women's singles semifinals of the \$250,000 Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament after registering hard-fought wins in their respective quarterfinals here on Friday.

World No. 50 Ashmita produced the biggest upset of the tournament so far, shocking top seed and World No. 22 Hina Akechi of Japan 20-22, 21-15, 21-19 in a gripping quarterfinal at the Asan Yi Sun-sin Gymnasium.

Rakshitha, meanwhile, came back from a game down to upset third seed and compatriot Tanvi Sharma 18-21, 21-19, 21-18 in a contest that lasted over an hour. It was her fourth win over Tanvi.

The results (quarterfinals):
Women: Ashmita Chaliha bt Hina Akechi 20-22, 21-15, 21-19; Rakshitha Ramraj bt Tanvi Sharma 18-21, 21-19, 21-18.
Men: Doubles: Man Wei Chong & Soh Wooi Yik bt Krishna Prasad Garaga & Pruthvi Krishnamurthy Roy 21-7, 21-8.

Former officials urge focus on structured pathway

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The absence of an Indian umpire or technical official at the upcoming FIH Men's Hockey World Cup after nearly three decades has left former international officials disappointed, with veterans saying the focus should be on a structured pathway.

For the first time since the 1998 World Cup in Utrecht, the tournament, beginning on August 15 in the Netherlands and Belgium, will not have any Indian umpire or technical official.

European dominance
European countries account for the bulk of the panel.

Raghu Prasad, the first Asian umpire to officiate in 200 international matches before retiring last year, said appointments for elite events are based on sustained performances in top-level competitions.

"The FIH Umpiring Committee selects officials

C'wealth Games champion Sachin keen to continue fine run in Asiad

The Haryana lad has follows the advice of his roommate-cum-mentor Panghal to overcome five years of struggle in Glasgow

BOXING
Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

Armed with hard work and resilience, Sachin Siwach followed the advice of his roommate-cum-mentor Amit Panghal to overcome five years of struggle, win Commonwealth Games gold, and finally make his mark at the elite level.

Sachin, who matched his fellow villager and namesake to become the second World Youth champion from Mitathal village in Haryana in 2021, battled injuries, questionable verdicts, and hard luck as he failed to make an impact at big events like the Asian Games, World Championships, and Olympic quali-



Gunning for glory: Sachin wants to make amends for failing to medal at the previous Asian Games. PTI

fiers. Meanwhile, he medalled at the Asian Championships and in World Boxing Cup stages.

Now, the CWG gold has

boosted his self-belief. "Sometimes it was my mistake, sometimes not. The setbacks made me stronger. The CWG title has motivated me. I reached the top of the ladder. It'll be easier from here on," Sachin, the men's 60kg champion in Glasgow, told *The Hindu*.

Neeraj is also human, we are confident he'll keep improving: Sumariwalla

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Brushing aside recent concerns around Neeraj Chopra's fitness and form, Athletics Federation of India's selection committee chairman Adille Sumariwalla has said that the "country's greatest athlete" does not deserve to be scrutinised for an occasional silver after consistently delivering gold for the past one decade.

The two-time Olympic medal-winning javelin thrower, who has been troubled by a lower back injury for nearly a year, produced a season's best effort of 86.48m to win silver at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

He had collected a gold at the same event in 2018 before being forced to miss the 2022 edition due to injury.

Sumariwalla said Nee-



Neeraj in Glasgow. PTI

raj's extraordinary consistency on the global stage since creating the still-standing junior world record of 86.48m in 2016, ought to be celebrated.

"After the injury, for him to come back to this stage and win a silver medal, it's simply fantastic, for Indian athletics. We are confident that he will keep on improving (in the coming days)," Sumariwalla, also a former president of the

AFI, said in a telephonic interview.

"It is not that he would win gold all the time, it doesn't happen like that. Silver medals also happen. He is also a human being, and we should leave at that. We should celebrate his silver medals also," he said.

"Who has given you two Olympic medals, a gold and a silver? Who has given you world championships gold, junior world record and a gold medal?"

"Who has given you Asian Games gold and Commonwealth Games gold and silver, and Asian Championships gold? Whatever medal he has won, we should take it as a bonus," he said.

"So, when he wins a silver medal also, we must leave it at that. We must not write him off. Whatever he has to do, he will do it and he knows it. He is after

all the greatest athlete India has produced."

Sumariwalla is not bothered by the lack of gold in Glasgow as he believes it was a "matter of small margins" for some Indian silver winners.

"Two medals in javelin, two in triple jump, nearly two in long jump, we have depth. We are now not dependent on just a few athletes to deliver. We had multiple finalists in many events," he noted.

"Moreover, we could send a limited number (32) of athletes this time (due to scaled-down Games). Otherwise, we could have fielded our athletes in more events and might have won more medals."

There were a couple of disappointments as well with Gurindervir Singh exiting after the first round heats in men's 100m and Animesh Kujur not making the 200m finals.

Ashfaq makes the 400m semifinals

Press Trust of India
EUGENE (USA)

Mohammed Ashfaq broke the U-20 National record to qualify for the men's 400m semifinals while Amanat Kamboj finished sixth in women's discus throw finals with a personal best effort on the second day of the World Athletics U-20 Championships here.

The 19-year-old Ashfaq clocked 45.81 seconds to finish second behind USA's Jayden DeLeon (45.63s) in the first round heat 5 and fourth overall to make the semifinals.

Ashfaq bettered his own previous national record of 46.05 seconds, set earlier this season in April.

Piyush Raj (47.78s) failed to proceed after finishing fifth in Heat 6 and 35th overall.

In the women's discus final, the 18-year-old Kamboj's first round throw of

Sachin credits much of his growth to Panghal. "He was my roommate and training partner (2023-2025). I learned a lot from him – how to rectify mistakes, about diet and rest. He told me about my weak points and strengths, how to block punches and how to move my legs. Amit *bhai* was World No.1 and has won big medals. I learned everything from him."

Indian men's team head coach C.A. Kuttappa wants to see certain improvements in Sachin. "He shouldn't bend too much. He was penalised for this in the final. Also, he should learn to adapt and box from different ranges as per the situation," said Kuttappa.

For now, Sachin is celebrating with his family before shifting his focus to Asiad preparation.

53.24m, her lifetime best, was good enough for a sixth-place finish.

In men's high jump, Basant qualified for the finals after finishing fifth in the qualification round Group A and 11th overall with a best clearance of 2.14m.

K. Ambrieshe cleared just 2.05m for a 12th place finish in the qualification round Group B and 24th overall.

Anshu missed out on a place in the women's shot put final after finishing ninth in her qualification group and 14th overall with a throw of 15.24m.

Tanu Chaudhary failed to make it to the women's 400m hurdles semifinals after finishing fifth in her heat and 33rd overall, clocking 1:00.03s.

Amit Kumar finished eighth and last in his heat in the men's 400m hurdles, clocking 54.01 seconds.

Rodriguinho slams five in SC Delhi's runaway victory

DURAND CUP

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

Brazilian forward Rodriguinho struck five goals on his Durand Cup debut as SC Delhi steamrollered Sri Lankan outfit Defenders FC 7-0 to record its second straight win in Group 'C' at the Birsa Munda Stadium (Morabadi) in Ranchi on Friday.

Mohammed Aimen and substitute Juan Sebastian Pena also contributed in Delhi's dominating performance, which helped the side sit atop its group with six points and move closer to a quarterfinal spot.

Sensational start
Delhi made a sensational start as Rodriguinho outwitted Defenders to achieve his hat-trick quickly. He brought down a pass, turned and unleashed a left-footer to open the account in the sixth minute and struck two more in the next six minutes.

After taking a 4-0 lead at the half-time, the Tomasz Tchorz-coached side pumped in three goals in the closing minutes with



Making merry: Rodriguinho had fun at Defenders' expense, netting his hat-trick in the first 12 minutes. INSTAGRAM/SCDELHI.OFFICIAL

Rodriguinho scoring two of those.

At the Salt Lake Stadium here, East Bengal outplayed South United FC 5-0 to post its second win and stay alive in the race for a spot in the last-eight.

The results: At Ranchi: Group C: SC Delhi 7 (Rodriguinho 6, 8, 12, 89, 90+5, Mohammed Aimen 34, Juan Sebastian Pena 90+2) bt Defenders FC 0.
At Kolkata: Group A: East Bengal 5 (Ramirez 6, Bashim Rashid 24, Bhaatt 73, Bipin 81, David Hmar 90+5) bt South United FC 0.

Anmol Ekka to lead India at Junior Asia Cup hockey

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Defender Anmol Ekka will lead an 18-member Indian men's hockey team at the AHF Junior Asia Cup to be held in Moqi, China from August 30 to September 13.

The Hockey India selectors also named two alternate players for the tournament in Arjun Santosh Hargude and Ritik Lakra.

The squad is currently training at the Sports Authority of India centre in Bengaluru under the guidance of newly-appointed coach Frederic Soyeyz.

The team is gaining further competitive exposure through friendly matches against the Malaysian U-21 team at the SAI centre.

The squad:
Defenders: Anmol Ekka (Capt.), Rohit Kullu, Chirag, Ravinder, Ashu Maurya, Sanjit Turkey and Sukhvinder.
Midfielders: Adrohit Ekka, Harpal, Jeetpal and Manmeet Singh Rai.
Forwards: Ajeet Yadav, Prabhdeep Singh, Gursewak Singh, Aryan Xess and Lovenoor Singh.
Alternate Players: Arjun Santosh Hargude and Ritik Lakra.